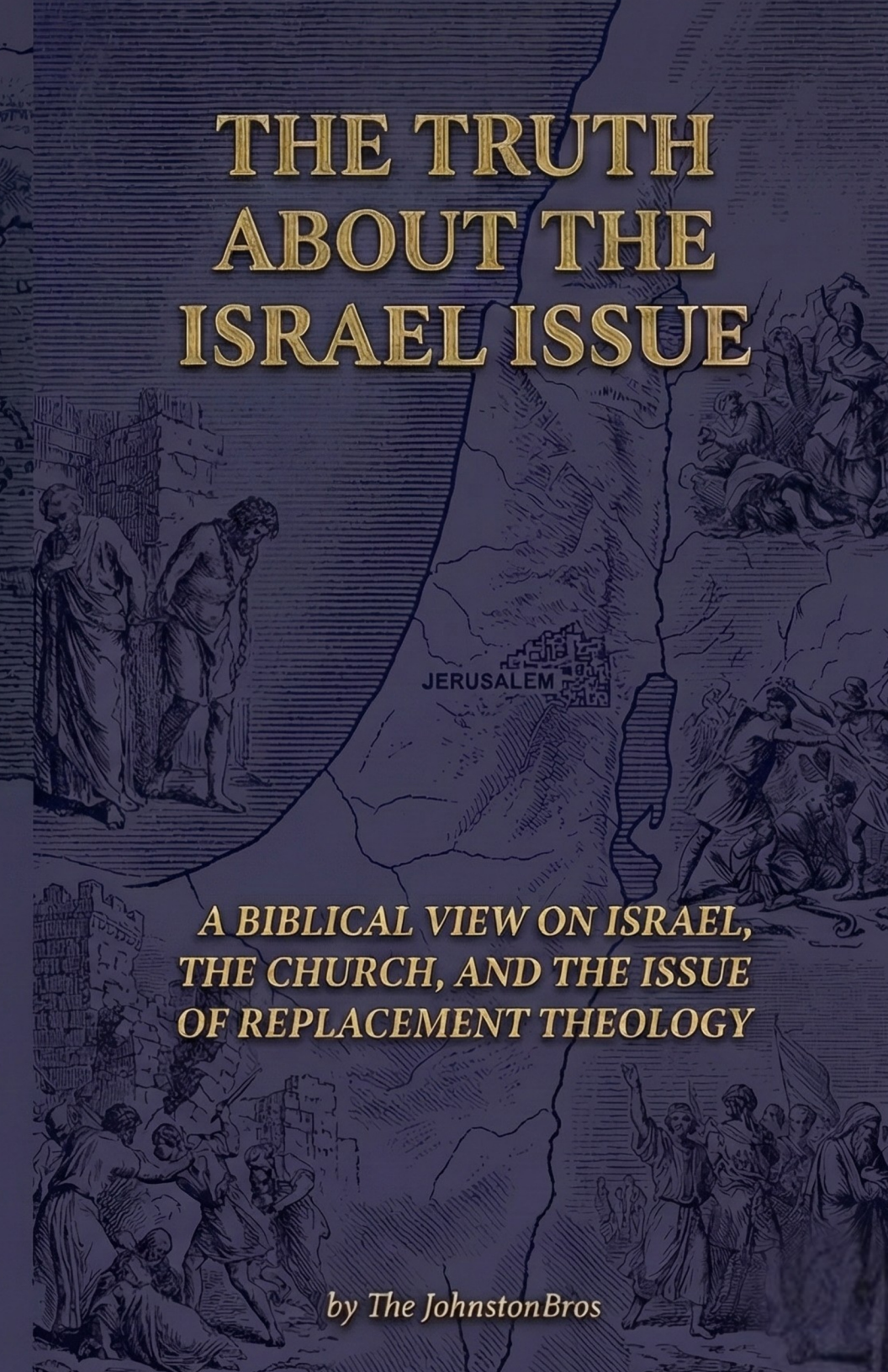
THE TRUTH ABOUT THE ISRAEL ISSUE



A BIBLICAL VIEW ON ISRAEL, THE CHURCH, AND THE ISSUE OF REPLACEMENT THEOLOGY

by The JohnstonBros

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ABOUT THE AUTHORS

Dr. Luke Johnston

Luke is a bi-vocational ministry leader, serving part-time at Millheim Baptist Church where he leads the youth ministry and is assisting in implementing a church-wide one-on-one discipleship model. He also works with State Farm. Luke is a graduate of the Greentown Bible Institute and holds a PhD in Biblical Studies.

Dr. Caleb Johnston

Caleb holds a Doctor of Pharmacy (PharmD) and currently serves as a practicing pharmacist. Alongside his career, he faithfully ministers to junior high students at Greentown Baptist Church and is completing his final year in the Greentown Bible Institute.

Jadon Johnston

Jadon is in his third year at the Greentown Bible Institute and leads the Evangelism Ministry (GEM) at Greentown Baptist Church and also the Vacation Bible School Ministry. He is passionate about reaching the lost and equipping saints, regularly teaching adult classes at GBC as well.

Micah Johnston

Micah is currently a junior at Manchester High School and actively serves in the youth ministry (EDGE) at Greentown Baptist Church. He is also an engaged in discipleship and evangelism, investing in peers and growing as a young leader in ministry.

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PREFACE 1
WHY THE QUESTION MATTERS 2
THE PROMISE TO ABRAM AND HIS SEED 8
THE THRONE OF DAVID 14
NATION AND INDIVIDUAL: ROMANS 2 17
NEITHER JEW NOR GREEK: GALATIANS 3 22
ROMANS 9: ISRAEL'S PAST 27
ROMANS 10: ISRAEL'S PRESENT 31
ROMANS 11: ISRAEL'S FUTURE 34
THE NEW COVENANT BELONGS TO ISRAEL 39
OTHER PASSAGES USED TO REPLACE ISRAEL 42
WHAT THE LORD JESUS AND THE APOSTLES TAUGHT 47
ISRAEL IN THE LAST DAYS 50
THE SCATTERING AND THE RETURN FORETOLD 57
A PEOPLE PRESERVED 61
HOW THE IDEA ENTERED THE CHURCH 68
A HOPE THE CHURCH NEVER LOST 74
CONCLUSION: ISRAEL MEANS ISRAEL 78
APPENDIX: PROMISES OF ISRAEL'S FUTURE 80
BIBLIOGRAPHY 85

PREFACE

Few questions in the modern world carry as much weight as the question of Israel. Who are the Israelites of today? What place does the nation hold in the purposes of God? Has the church inherited Israel's promises, or does Israel still have a future according to Scripture? These questions are not merely academic. They have shaped the history of the church, influenced the policies of nations, and divided Christians who read the same Bible. Scripture itself anticipated this. God called Jerusalem "a burdensome stone for all people" and warned that "all that burden themselves with it shall be cut in pieces, though all the people of the earth be gathered together against it" (Zech. 12:3).

This book approaches the subject from Scripture rather than from politics or inherited tradition. It is not a defense of any government or political party. The people of the modern state of Israel are sinners in need of a Savior, as are the people of every nation, and most of them do not yet believe that Jesus is the Christ. The conduct of the nation, however, is not the question before us. The question is whether God has kept his word. If God made unconditional promises to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob and to their descendants, and then transferred those promises to another people, his word could not be trusted. If he has not transferred them, then the teaching that the church has replaced Israel rests on a misreading of Scripture, and the consequences of that misreading are serious.

The four of us are brothers who have studied and debated these passages together for years. The argument that follows is built from the text of Scripture, and it relies throughout on a basic principle of interpretation: Scripture interprets Scripture. We do not claim to have answered every question. We do contend that the Bible means what it says, and that when God speaks of Israel, he means Israel.

WHY THE QUESTION MATTERS

In recent years, questions about Israel's identity, its place in the world, and its role in history, biblical prophecy, and the biblical narrative have drawn increasing attention. These questions lie at the heart of this book. Two recent examples illustrate how these issues are commonly presented in Christendom today.

Jeff Durbin, the host of *Apologia Radio*, argued on his program that the common evangelical view of Israel does not come from the Bible. He described how many Christians have been taught that the Jewish people are "God's chosen people" while the church is treated almost as a secondary family. He then read Romans 2:28–29, "For he is not a Jew, which is one outwardly; neither is that circumcision, which is outward in the flesh: But he is a Jew, which is one inwardly; and circumcision is that of the heart, in the spirit, and not in the letter" (Rom. 2:28–29), and asked, "Can you get more explicit than that?" From this passage he concluded that a person is "not even truly Jewish" because of physical descent: "You have to be inwardly Jewish."[1]

The actor Kirk Cameron made a related argument from Genesis in a podcast episode released on September 5, 2025, responding to a public exchange between Senator Ted Cruz and Tucker Carlson. "The verse that Tucker Carlson's talking about in Genesis actually doesn't say Israel," Cameron said. "It says that those who bless you, Abraham, this was before Israel, will be blessed by God and those who curse you, Abraham, will be cursed by God." He added that Israel "didn't have a nation or a land to call their own for almost 2,000 years since the destruction of the temple in the year 70 AD," and that the modern nation

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[1]Jeff Durbin, "Is Modern Israel 'God's Chosen People'? | Apologia Radio Highlight," Apologia Studios, YouTube video, 12:41, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=p4yRH9rA3_o; transcript mirrored at https://lets.church/media/xvh729DjxR3fkz3uK6LgZG. Durbin read the passage from the English Standard Version; we have given it in the King James wording.

"was recreated through some political operatives after World War II." His conclusion was a question: "So in that almost 2,000-year period, what did it even mean to bless Israel or to curse Israel? There was no Israel, per se."[2]

These arguments, and others like them, represent what is commonly called *replacement theology*. Many of its advocates prefer the term *supersessionism*, but the central claim is the same: the national promises God made to Israel throughout the Old Testament no longer belong to the physical descendants of Jacob. On this view the church has replaced, superseded, or fulfilled Israel, and the promises of land, throne, and kingdom have been given a spiritual meaning and applied to the church. The Jewish people, as a nation, have no distinct future in the plan of God.

Three Kinds of People

Scripture divides mankind into three groups: "Give none offence, neither to the Jews, nor to the Gentiles, nor to the church of God" (1 Cor. 10:32). The Jew is the physical descendant of Jacob. The Gentile is everyone else. The church is the body of Christ, composed of Jews and Gentiles who have believed the gospel in the present age. When these three categories are kept distinct, much of the confusion surrounding this subject disappears. When they are merged, the prophets can no longer be read as they were written.

The names themselves point to a people rather than an idea. The word *Jew* is derived from Judah. It first referred to a member of the tribe of Judah, then to a citizen of the kingdom of Judah, and eventually to the nation as a whole. The word *Hebrew* reaches further back, to Eber, an ancestor of Abraham (Gen. 10:21; 11:14–

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[2]Kirk Cameron, podcast episode of September 5, 2025, as transcribed in Ray Fava, "Kirk Cameron vs Christian Zionism," *Evangelical Dark Web*, September 17, 2025, https://evangelicaldarkweb.org/2025/09/17/kirk-cameron-vs-christian-zionism/. Cameron also posted a shortened clip of this segment on X and later removed it; the full episode remained available.

26), and Abraham is the first man in Scripture called "Abram the Hebrew" (Gen. 14:13). These are the names of a family and a nation. They were never used as names for a spiritual category.

Principles of Interpretation

Most doctrinal errors arise from the same basic mistakes. A verse is removed from its chapter, the chapter from its book, and the book from the rest of Scripture. Paul instructed Timothy, "Study to shew thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth" (2 Tim. 2:15). To study is to read more than a single verse. To divide rightly is to ask who is speaking, to whom, and about what subject. To consider the whole counsel of God is to allow the Bible to define its own terms.

When these principles are applied, a pattern emerges in the passages most often used to support replacement theology. Romans 2, Galatians 3, and Romans 9 are not primarily concerned with God's national promises to Israel. They are concerned with individual justification, the question of how a sinner is made right with God. Paul's point in each place is that no one is justified by nationality, and that has always been true. The error comes when a truth about individual salvation is used to conclude that God has finished with Israel as a nation. These are different questions, and Scripture answers them differently.

A second pattern is the shifting use of terms. In replacement teaching, *Israel* may refer to the church in one verse, to the Jewish people in the next, and to the elect a few lines later. The word *Jew* is treated the same way. An interpretation that requires a key term to change meaning from sentence to sentence should be questioned. Throughout this book we will follow a simpler rule: when Scripture says Israel, we will understand it to mean Israel unless the text itself indicates otherwise.

Why It Matters

Doctrine is never merely theoretical. "Be not deceived: evil communications corrupt good manners" (1 Cor. 15:33). In context Paul is addressing false teaching about the resurrection, and his point is that error in belief produces error in conduct. What Christians believe about Israel shapes how they read the prophets, how they understand the Lord's return, how they pray, and how they regard the Jewish people. As later chapters will show, the history of the church confirms this. Christian communities that have believed God cast off Israel have seldom treated the Jewish people with kindness.

The question also bears directly on the character of God. If God can make an everlasting covenant and later set it aside, his other promises are no more secure. The same Scriptures that promise eternal life to every believer promise an everlasting covenant to Abraham's descendants. The one cannot be read literally and the other figuratively without undermining both. The thesis of this book is that the inclusion of the church does not cancel Israel's promises. The chapters that follow test that thesis against the text of Scripture.

Common Objections

Before turning to the key passages, it will be useful to answer the objections most often raised against a future for national Israel.

Objection: The promise of Genesis 12 was made to Abram, not to Israel. The promise was made to Abram and to his seed, as the same chapter states (Gen. 12:7), and it is repeated and expanded in the chapters that follow. The next chapter examines those passages in detail. The promise did not end with Abram.

Objection: There was no nation of Israel for nearly two thousand years, so the promises cannot refer to the modern state. The long absence of the nation was itself foretold. Hosea wrote, "For the children of Israel shall abide many days without a king, and without a prince, and without a sacrifice… Afterward shall the children of Israel return, and seek the LORD their God, and David their

king; and shall fear the LORD and his goodness in the latter days" (Hos. 3:4–5). Moses had said that after the people were scattered among the nations, "the LORD thy God will turn thy captivity, and have compassion upon thee, and will return and gather thee from all the nations, whither the LORD thy God hath scattered thee" (Deut. 30:3). A long period without a nation, followed by a return, is precisely what the prophets predicted. The centuries of dispersion do not disprove the promise; they fulfill its first part.

Objection: The modern state of Israel was created by political means after World War II. God has always used rulers and governments to accomplish his purposes for his people. He named the Persian king Cyrus in advance and said of him, "He is my shepherd, and shall perform all my pleasure: even saying to Jerusalem, Thou shalt be built" (Isa. 44:28). Cyrus was a pagan ruler, and the return from Babylon came by his decree (Ezra 1:1–3). The use of political means in 1948 no more excludes the hand of God than Cyrus's decree did in 538 B.C.

Objection: A people who reject Christ and oppose Christians cannot be God's chosen people. Israel's election has never rested on Israel's faithfulness. Moses told the nation, "Understand therefore, that the LORD thy God giveth thee not this good land to possess it for thy righteousness; for thou art a stiffnecked people" (Deut. 9:6). When God promised to regather Israel in the last days, he said, "I do not this for your sakes, O house of Israel, but for mine holy name's sake" (Ezek. 36:22). Paul describes the unbelieving nation as enemies of the gospel and, in the same sentence, as "beloved for the fathers' sakes" (Rom. 11:28). Both statements are true at the same time.

Objection: Jesus himself said that the unbelieving Jews were not Abraham's children. He did, and the way he said it supports the distinction this book defends. In the same conversation he told his opponents, "I know that ye are Abraham's seed" (John 8:37), and then, "If ye were Abraham's children, ye would do the works of Abraham" (John 8:39). They were Abraham's

descendants by birth, and the Lord acknowledged it. They were not his children in the sense of sharing his faith. Christ distinguished the natural descendants from the spiritual children without denying the existence of either.

THE PROMISE TO ABRAM AND HIS SEED

Replacement teachers are fond of reminding us that God's promise in Genesis 12 was made to Abram before there was a nation of Israel. That is true, and it proves the opposite of what they intend. The passage must be read in full, including the verses that follow.

Genesis 12:1–3

"Now the LORD had said unto Abram, Get thee out of thy country, and from thy kindred, and from thy father's house, unto a land that I will shew thee: And I will make of thee a great nation, and I will bless thee, and make thy name great; and thou shalt be a blessing: And I will bless them that bless thee, and curse him that curseth thee: and in thee shall all families of the earth be blessed."

The very first promise is "I will make of thee a great nation." God did not promise Abram a private blessing that would die with him. He promised a nation. Four verses later he made the scope even clearer: "And the LORD appeared unto Abram, and said, Unto thy seed will I give this land" (Gen. 12:7). The land was promised to the seed. The promises to Abraham were never just about Abraham, just as the promises to Jacob were never just about Jacob. The promise concerned a family that would become a nation.

An Everlasting Covenant

God did not leave the matter at Genesis 12. He repeated the promise, enlarged it, and sealed it. In Genesis 15 he passed alone between the pieces of the sacrifice while Abram slept, binding himself and no one else to the covenant (Gen. 15:12–18). In Genesis 17 he spelled out its duration:

Genesis 17:7–8

"And I will establish my covenant between me and thee and thy seed after thee in their generations for an everlasting covenant, to be a God unto thee, and to thy seed after thee. And I will give unto thee, and to

thy seed after thee, the land wherein thou art a stranger, all the land of Canaan, for an everlasting possession; and I will be their God."

Three features of this promise deserve attention. The covenant is between God and Abraham's seed "in their generations." It is "an everlasting covenant." And the land is given "for an everlasting possession." None of those words is difficult. If everlasting does not mean everlasting here, we have no reason to think it means everlasting in John 3:16.

God confirmed the same oath to Isaac (Gen. 26:3–4) and to Jacob (Gen. 28:13–14), and he renamed Jacob Israel (Gen. 32:28). The psalmist summed it up this way:

Psalm 105:8–11

"He hath remembered his covenant for ever, the word which he commanded to a thousand generations. Which covenant he made with Abraham, and his oath unto Isaac; And confirmed the same unto Jacob for a law, and to Israel for an everlasting covenant: Saying, Unto thee will I give the land of Canaan, the lot of your inheritance."

That is the line of the promise: Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, Israel. It runs through a family and into a nation.

Conditional and Unconditional Promises

God is careful and precise in the way he speaks. Some of his promises are conditional, and he says so: "If ye walk in my statutes… Then I will give you rain in due season" (Lev. 26:3–4). Others rest on his word alone. The covenant with Abraham, the promise of the land, and the covenant with David are of the second kind. Israel's disobedience could bring chastening, scattering, and loss of the land for a time, and the law warned them it would. But God said in the same chapter that Israel's sin would not cancel his covenant:

Leviticus 26:44–45

"And yet for all that, when they be in the land of their enemies, I will not cast them away, neither will I abhor them, to destroy them utterly,

and to break my covenant with them: for I am the LORD their God. But I will for their sakes remember the covenant of their ancestors, whom I brought forth out of the land of Egypt in the sight of the heathen, that I might be their God: I am the LORD."

Jeremiah went further. He tied Israel's survival as a nation to the fixed order of the sun, moon, and stars: "If those ordinances depart from before me, saith the LORD, then the seed of Israel also shall cease from being a nation before me for ever" (Jer. 31:36). The sun still came up this morning. As long as it does, Israel remains a nation before God.

Paul himself settled the question of whether a later arrangement could cancel the promise to Abraham. "And this I say, that the covenant, that was confirmed before of God in Christ, the law, which was four hundred and thirty years after, cannot disannul, that it should make the promise of none effect" (Gal. 3:17). If the law of Moses, given by God himself at Sinai, could not cancel the covenant with Abraham, then nothing that came later can cancel it either. That argument cuts against replacement theology in the very book its defenders quote most. The church age came far more than four hundred and thirty years after Abraham, and it cannot disannul the promise any more than the law could.

The way God ratified the covenant tells the same story. In Genesis 15 Abram cut the animals in two and laid the halves opposite each other. In that day, when two parties made a covenant, both walked between the pieces, calling down on themselves the fate of the slain animals if they broke their word. Jeremiah describes the practice: "the men that have transgressed my covenant, which have not performed the words of the covenant which they had made before me, when they cut the calf in twain, and passed between the parts thereof" (Jer. 34:18). But in Genesis 15 Abram did not walk between the pieces. A deep sleep fell on him, and "a smoking furnace, and a burning lamp" passed between them alone (Gen. 15:12, 17). God bound himself while Abram slept. The covenant rested on one party only, and that party cannot lie.

The Covenant with David

The covenant with David was built the same way. God promised David a house, a kingdom, and a throne established for ever (2 Sam. 7:12–16). Then, speaking of David's descendants, he anticipated their failure in advance and said it would not cancel the promise:

Psalm 89:30–36

"If his children forsake my law, and walk not in my judgments; If they break my statutes, and keep not my commandments; Then will I visit their transgression with the rod, and their iniquity with stripes. Nevertheless my lovingkindness will I not utterly take from him, nor suffer my faithfulness to fail. My covenant will I not break, nor alter the thing that is gone out of my lips. Once have I sworn by my holiness that I will not lie unto David. His seed shall endure for ever, and his throne as the sun before me."

This is an accurate summary of Israel's later history. The children did forsake his law. He did visit their transgression with the rod. And he said ahead of time that none of it would break his covenant. Jeremiah ties this promise, too, to the order of creation: "If my covenant be not with day and night, and if I have not appointed the ordinances of heaven and earth; Then will I cast away the seed of Jacob, and David my servant… for I will cause their captivity to return, and have mercy on them" (Jer. 33:25–26). Day and night have not stopped. Neither has God's covenant with the seed of Jacob.

The Land

The land is the part of the promise that replacement theology is most eager to spiritualize, because it is the part that is hardest to apply to the church. Yet God was specific about it. "In the same day the LORD made a covenant with Abram, saying, Unto thy seed have I given this land, from the river of Egypt unto the great river, the river Euphrates" (Gen. 15:18). He named its borders. He called it "an everlasting possession" (Gen. 17:8).

Some answer that the land promise was already fulfilled under Joshua. They point to Joshua 21: "And the LORD gave unto Israel all the land which he sware to give unto their fathers; and they possessed it, and dwelt therein… There failed not ought of any good thing which the LORD had spoken unto the house of Israel; all came to pass" (Josh. 21:43, 45). God certainly kept his word in Joshua's day. But the promise was an *everlasting* possession, and Israel was later carried away to Assyria and Babylon and then scattered by Rome. Whatever was fulfilled under Joshua, it was not the final fulfillment. The prophets, writing centuries after Joshua, still looked forward to a planting in the land that would never be undone:

Amos 9:14–15

"And I will bring again the captivity of my people of Israel, and they shall build the waste cities, and inhabit them; and they shall plant vineyards, and drink the wine thereof; they shall also make gardens, and eat the fruit of them. And I will plant them upon their land, and they shall no more be pulled up out of their land which I have given them, saith the LORD thy God."

"They shall no more be pulled up out of their land." That has never yet been true. After Amos wrote it, Israel was pulled up again and again. Amos, then, was not describing Joshua's conquest or the return from Babylon. He was describing a future planting that God himself will guarantee. The land is described as "their land which I have given them"; it belongs to Israel, not to the church.

Sand and Stars

God described Abraham's seed with more than one picture. He said it would be "as the dust of the earth" (Gen. 13:16), "as the stars of the heaven, and as the sand which is upon the sea shore" (Gen. 22:17). Many Bible teachers have seen in those two images, one earthly and one heavenly, a picture of the two aspects of Abraham's seed: a natural, earthly people with an earthly inheritance, and a spiritual people, those who share Abraham's

faith. Both are innumerable to man (Jer. 33:22), but they are not the same thing. The New Testament affirms both. Believers are Abraham's children by faith (Gal. 3:7). Yet the same apostle calls the unbelieving Jews "my kinsmen according to the flesh: Who are Israelites" (Rom. 9:3–4). The spiritual seed does not erase the natural seed. The spiritual seed is added to the natural seed; it does not replace it.

Why God Chose a Nation

God did not choose Israel because they were impressive. Moses told them so: "The LORD did not set his love upon you, nor choose you, because ye were more in number than any people; for ye were the fewest of all people: But because the LORD loved you, and because he would keep the oath which he had sworn unto your fathers" (Deut. 7:7–8). Israel's election as a nation rests on God's love and God's oath. That is why it cannot be undone by Israel's failure. Their failure is real, and God judged it. But his oath does not depend on them.

Nor did national election ever guarantee individual salvation. From the beginning God wanted his people to love him from the heart: "And thou shalt love the LORD thy God with all thine heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy might. And these words, which I command thee this day, shall be in thine heart" (Deut. 6:5–6). Being born into Israel gave a man enormous advantages, as we will see. It never made him right with God by itself. Keep that distinction in view, national promises on one hand and personal justification on the other, and the passages that seem to support replacement theology begin to read very differently.

THE THRONE OF DAVID

We saw in the last chapter that God swore to David a house, a kingdom, and a throne established for ever, and that he promised in advance that the sins of David's children would not break that covenant (Ps. 89:30–36). This promise deserves a chapter of its own, because it is one of the clearest tests of how a person reads the Bible. It is tied to a particular family, a particular nation, and a particular city. If it can be spiritualized, anything can.

Christ Is the Son of David

The New Testament opens with these words: "The book of the generation of Jesus Christ, the son of David, the son of Abraham" (Matt. 1:1). The Lord Jesus is the heir of both covenants. The angel told Mary, "the Lord God shall give unto him the throne of his father David: And he shall reign over the house of Jacob for ever; and of his kingdom there shall be no end" (Luke 1:32–33). The throne is David's throne. The people are the house of Jacob. Gabriel chose his words carefully, and neither of them is a symbol.

Jeremiah, writing while the last kings of Judah were being carried off to Babylon, said that David's line would never lose its right to the throne:

Jeremiah 33:20–21

"If ye can break my covenant of the day, and my covenant of the night, and that there should not be day and night in their season; Then may also my covenant be broken with David my servant, that he should not have a son to reign upon his throne."

There has been no Davidic king in Jerusalem since the Babylonian captivity. Yet the covenant stands, because David's greatest Son is alive and will reign.

Two Thrones

Some teach that Christ took David's throne when he ascended to heaven, so that nothing is left to be fulfilled on earth. But the Lord Jesus himself distinguished two thrones: "To him that overcometh will I grant to sit with me in my throne, even as I also overcame, and am set down with my Father in his throne" (Rev. 3:21). Today the Lord sits with his Father in the Father's throne. There is also "my throne," which his people will share with him in the future. And he told us when he will take it: "When the Son of man shall come in his glory, and all the holy angels with him, then shall he sit upon the throne of his glory" (Matt. 25:31). The throne of his glory comes with his return.

Peter's sermon at Pentecost points the same way. David, "being a prophet, and knowing that God had sworn with an oath to him, that of the fruit of his loins, according to the flesh, he would raise up Christ to sit on his throne" (Acts 2:30), spoke of the resurrection. The resurrection guarantees that David's Son is alive to sit on David's throne. It does not turn David's throne into something else.

After This I Will Return

The clearest statement of the order of events comes from the council at Jerusalem. The apostles were debating whether Gentile believers had to be circumcised, and James summed up what God was doing: "Simeon hath declared how God at the first did visit the Gentiles, to take out of them a people for his name" (Acts 15:14). That is the present age: God taking out a people for his name from among the Gentiles. Then James quoted the prophet Amos: "After this I will return, and will build again the tabernacle of David, which is fallen down; and I will build again the ruins thereof, and I will set it up" (Acts 15:16).

After this. After God takes out a people from the Gentiles, he will return and rebuild the fallen house of David. James did not say the church is the tabernacle of David. He said the church comes

first, and then God turns back to David's house. The prophecy he quoted ends with a promise that has never yet been fulfilled: "And I will plant them upon their land, and they shall no more be pulled up out of their land which I have given them, saith the LORD thy God" (Amos 9:15). That cannot describe the return from Babylon, because the Jews were pulled up out of their land again by Rome. It is still future.

Ezekiel says the same thing in the chapter of the dry bones:

Ezekiel 37:24–25

"And David my servant shall be king over them; and they all shall have one shepherd… And they shall dwell in the land that I have given unto Jacob my servant, wherein your fathers have dwelt; and they shall dwell therein, even they, and their children, and their children's children for ever."

The land, the people, the king, for ever. Every part of the covenant is there.

If David's throne becomes Christ's present reign in heaven, and the house of Jacob becomes the church, then Jeremiah's promise that David would never lack a son to reign "upon his throne," and Amos's promise that Israel would "no more be pulled up out of their land," lose their meaning. But if God meant what he swore, a day is coming when the Son of David will reign in Jerusalem over a restored Israel. We believe he meant it. "Once have I sworn by my holiness that I will not lie unto David" (Ps. 89:35).

NATION AND INDIVIDUAL: ROMANS 2

We come now to the verse that is quoted more than any other in this debate.

Romans 2:28–29

"For he is not a Jew, which is one outwardly; neither is that circumcision, which is outward in the flesh: But he is a Jew, which is one inwardly; and circumcision is that of the heart, in the spirit, and not in the letter; whose praise is not of men, but of God."

Read by itself, it can sound as if Paul is redefining the word Jew so that it now means any believer. Read in its place, it says something else.

The Context of Romans 2

Romans is the most orderly doctrinal letter in the Bible. In the first three chapters Paul builds a single case: everyone is guilty before God. In chapter 1 he shows the guilt of the pagan world. In chapter 2 he turns to the religious man, and especially to the Jew who rested in the law and made his boast of God (Rom. 2:17). Paul's point is that the law condemns the Jew as surely as it condemns the Gentile. "For circumcision verily profiteth, if thou keep the law: but if thou be a breaker of the law, thy circumcision is made uncircumcision" (Rom. 2:25). By chapter 3 the verdict is universal: "we have before proved both Jews and Gentiles, that they are all under sin" (Rom. 3:9).

The subject of Romans 2, then, is not God's national plan for Israel. The subject is whether a man can stand before God on the strength of his circumcision. The answer is no. A Jew who breaks the law has no more standing before God than a Gentile who never had it. What God looks for is a circumcised heart.

Even the wording carries the point. Judah means praise; when Leah bore him she said, "Now will I praise the LORD: therefore she called his name Judah" (Gen. 29:35), and Jacob later said, "Judah, thou art he whom thy brethren shall praise" (Gen. 49:8).

When Paul says the true Jew is one "whose praise is not of men, but of God," he is playing on the very name. The man who pleases God is the one whose heart is right with him, not the one who can point to a mark in his flesh.

Keep Reading

The decisive question is what Paul says next. If he had just abolished any meaningful difference between Jew and Gentile, the following verses would say so. He answers the question himself in the very next verses, and it is amazing how often those verses are left out. "What advantage then hath the Jew? or what profit is there of circumcision? Much every way: chiefly, because that unto them were committed the oracles of God" (Rom. 3:1–2).

The Jew in view here is not the believer who is a Jew "inwardly." Paul is speaking of the physical Jew, the circumcised man of Romans 2, and he says that this Jew has "much every way" of advantage. That advantage is national and historical. God gave his word to Israel. He gave them the law, the prophets, the covenants, and the Messiah. Nearly every book of the Bible was written by an Israelite; at most one or two writers may have been Gentiles, with Luke the likeliest. Paul's point in Romans 2 is that none of those advantages justifies an individual sinner. His point in Romans 3 is that the advantages are real. Both are true at the same time, and neither cancels the other.

Circumcision of the Heart Is Not New

Some write as if Paul invented the idea of heart circumcision in Romans and used it to set aside Israel. In fact Moses taught it fifteen centuries earlier. "Circumcise therefore the foreskin of your heart, and be no more stiffnecked" (Deut. 10:16). "And the LORD thy God will circumcise thine heart, and the heart of thy seed, to love the LORD thy God with all thine heart, and with all thy soul, that thou mayest live" (Deut. 30:6). Jeremiah pressed the same demand on the nation: "Circumcise yourselves to the

LORD, and take away the foreskins of your heart, ye men of Judah and inhabitants of Jerusalem" (Jer. 4:4).

Jeremiah was addressing "ye men of Judah." They were Jews by birth, and he said so. Their hearts were uncircumcised, and God was warning them of judgment. Yet he did not say they had ceased to be Jews. He said they were Jews who were not right with God. This is Paul's point in Romans 2. Deuteronomy 30:6 is also significant. God promised to circumcise "thine heart, and the heart of thy seed." There is a personal circumcision of the heart, and there is a national one that God has promised to Israel in the future. The New Testament describes the personal side for believers today: "In whom also ye are circumcised with the circumcision made without hands, in putting off the body of the sins of the flesh by the circumcision of Christ" (Col. 2:11). That spiritual circumcision takes place the moment a sinner is saved. It pictures what God will one day do for the nation. It does not replace the nation.

There is a pattern here that runs all through the Bible. Things that were physical in the Old Testament often have a spiritual application in the New. That is a real and precious principle. But a spiritual application never erases the literal promise that stands behind it. God is not a liar.

Examples on Both Sides

The Old Testament is full of people who prove that national identity and personal standing with God are separate matters. On one side stand men who were Israelites by birth and yet perished in rebellion. Korah was a Levite and a close kinsman of Moses, yet he, Dathan, and Abiram went down alive into the pit (Num. 16:31–33). King Saul was a Benjamite and the anointed king of Israel, and he ended his life seeking a witch at Endor (1 Sam. 28:7). Their nationality did not save them.

On the other side stand Gentiles who believed God and were brought in. Rahab was a Canaanite harlot who believed what she had heard of Israel's God and hid the spies (Josh. 2:9–11). She is

named in the hall of faith (Heb. 11:31) and in the genealogy of the Lord Jesus Christ (Matt. 1:5). Ruth was a Moabitess who said, "thy people shall be my people, and thy God my God" (Ruth 1:16), and a whole book of the Bible bears her name. The Gibeonites were a Canaanite people who by a ruse made peace with Israel and lived among them from then on (Josh. 9). None of these cases changed who Israel was. Gentiles could be joined to Israel, and Israelites could perish in unbelief, but the nation remained the nation.

Children of the Kingdom

The Lord Jesus made the same distinction. When a Roman centurion showed a faith that made the Lord marvel, he said:

Matthew 8:10–12

"I have not found so great faith, no, not in Israel. And I say unto you, That many shall come from the east and west, and shall sit down with Abraham, and Isaac, and Jacob, in the kingdom of heaven. But the children of the kingdom shall be cast out into outer darkness: there shall be weeping and gnashing of teeth."

The phrase is striking. The "children of the kingdom" could be cast out only because belonging to the kingdom's people by birth is one thing and personal salvation is another. The Jews to whom the kingdom promises belonged were the children of the kingdom. Yet individuals among them who rejected the King would be shut out. Their national privilege was real, and it made their unbelief more serious, not less. "For the wages of sin is death; but the gift of God is eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord" (Rom. 6:23). That applies to everyone. No one is exempt because of his lineage, and no one is excluded because of it.

Romans 2, therefore, does not teach that the church has become Israel. It teaches that no Jew is justified by his circumcision, which Moses and the prophets had taught all along. It is easy to see a verse like Romans 2:28 posted online and think it settles the matter. Some who knock on doors use the very same verse to argue that the 144,000 of Revelation are not literal Israelites. But

when the verse is read in its chapter, with the next chapter, and with the rest of the Bible, it says what it says, and not what it is being made to say.

NEITHER JEW NOR GREEK: GALATIANS 3

The second passage in almost every argument for replacement theology is Galatians 3:28–29. "There is neither Jew nor Greek, there is neither bond nor free, there is neither male nor female: for ye are all one in Christ Jesus. And if ye be Christ's, then are ye Abraham's seed, and heirs according to the promise." If there is neither Jew nor Greek, the argument goes, then national Israel no longer exists in God's eyes, and the church, as Abraham's seed, has inherited all his promises.

What Galatians Is About

Galatians is a letter against legalism. False teachers had come into the Galatian churches insisting that Gentile believers must be circumcised and keep the law of Moses in order to be saved. Paul answers that "a man is not justified by the works of the law, but by the faith of Jesus Christ" (Gal. 2:16). Abraham himself "believed God, and it was accounted to him for righteousness" (Gal. 3:6). The law was "our schoolmaster to bring us unto Christ, that we might be justified by faith" (Gal. 3:24). The whole letter is about how a sinner is justified. That is the context of verse 28.

When Paul says "there is neither Jew nor Greek," he is saying that neither group has better access to Christ. Being a Jew gives no advantage in being justified, and being a Greek is no hindrance. Verse 26 says it plainly: "For ye are all the children of God by faith in Christ Jesus." Faith is the way in, for everybody.

Be Consistent

Now apply the replacement reading consistently. If "neither Jew nor Greek" means national Jews have ceased to exist, then "neither bond nor free" means there are no more servants and masters, and "neither male nor female" means there are no more men and women. Yet the same apostle gave detailed instructions to servants and masters (Eph. 6:5–9) and to husbands and wives (Eph. 5:22–33), and he restricted the pastoral office to men (1

Tim. 2:12; 3:2). Nobody who uses Galatians 3:28 to erase Israel would use it to erase the order of the home or the qualifications for a pastor. If that is your method of reading the Bible, you must use it the same way every time. You cannot stop at the phrase that suits you.

What the verse actually means is that in Christ, as it touches salvation, all stand on equal ground. A man and a woman are equally saved. A slave and a free man are equally saved. A Jew and a Greek are equally saved. The distinctions remain in their proper spheres; they simply have no bearing on justification.

Abraham's Seed

Verse 29 must also be considered. "And if ye be Christ's, then are ye Abraham's seed, and heirs according to the promise." Paul first explains how believers become Abraham's seed: by being Christ's. Christ is the seed of Abraham (Gal. 3:16), and Christ was a Jew. When a sinner believes, he is placed in Christ, and in Christ he partakes of the blessing promised to Abraham. That is a real and glorious truth. The verse, however, does not say what replacement teaching requires. It does not say that the Jews are no longer Abraham's seed. It says that believing Gentiles have been brought in. Being added to the heirs does not remove the heirs who were already there.

The Bible even shows us that Abraham could have more than one kind of son. Abraham had Ishmael and Isaac, and Isaac had Esau and Jacob. Yet Hebrews says that Abraham "offered up his only begotten son" (Heb. 11:17), speaking of Isaac. He had other sons, but Isaac was the son of promise, the one through whom the promise came and the one who received it. God told Abraham, "in Isaac shall thy seed be called," and in the same breath, "And also of the son of the bondwoman will I make a nation, because he is thy seed" (Gen. 21:12–13). Ishmael was not the son of promise, yet God still made him a nation because he was Abraham's seed according to the flesh. The spiritual line and the physical line are both acknowledged. Neither line absorbs the other.

The Seed, Which Is Christ

Just before this passage Paul makes a point about grammar: "Now to Abraham and his seed were the promises made. He saith not, And to seeds, as of many; but as of one, And to thy seed, which is Christ" (Gal. 3:16). Some take this to mean that the promises now belong only to Christ, and therefore only to those in Christ, so that physical Israel has no further claim. But Paul's point is that the promise of blessing to all nations came through one particular descendant of Abraham, the Messiah. Christ is the heir of every promise God ever made, including the promises to Israel. Christ will sit on David's throne and reign over the house of Jacob (Luke 1:32–33). That the promises are fulfilled *in* Christ does not mean they are taken *from* Israel. It means Israel's King will fulfill them.

The Allegory of Hagar and Sarah

In the next chapter Paul contrasts Hagar and Sarah, and "Jerusalem which now is" with "Jerusalem which is above" (Gal. 4:25–26). Some read this as God disowning earthly Jerusalem and the Jewish people forever. But Paul tells us plainly what he is doing: "Which things are an allegory: for these are the two covenants; the one from the mount Sinai, which gendereth to bondage, which is Agar" (Gal. 4:24). The two women represent two covenants, law and grace. Hagar stands for Sinai and for the Jerusalem of Paul's day, which was in bondage to the law and had rejected Christ. Sarah stands for the promise and for "Jerusalem which is above," which "is free, which is the mother of us all" (Gal. 4:26).

That contrast is about how a person is saved, by the law or by promise, and every believer, Jew or Gentile, is a child of promise. It says nothing about God's future for the nation. The same Old Testament that gives us Hagar and Sarah also tells us that the Lord's feet will stand on the mount of Olives before Jerusalem (Zech. 14:4), and the same apostle who wrote Galatians 4 wrote Romans 11. Paul called it an allegory himself. An allegory used

to illustrate law and grace cannot be turned into a doctrine that cancels a covenant God swore by himself.

Paul Did Not Erase the Distinction

If Paul had meant to abolish Jewish identity in Galatians 3, he contradicted himself one chapter earlier. There he wrote that "the gospel of the uncircumcision was committed unto me, as the gospel of the circumcision was unto Peter" (Gal. 2:7), and that James, Cephas, and John agreed "that we should go unto the heathen, and they unto the circumcision" (Gal. 2:9). Paul still recognized a ministry to Jews as Jews. Throughout the book of Acts he went to the synagogue first, because the gospel was "to the Jew first, and also to the Greek" (Rom. 1:16). James wrote his epistle "to the twelve tribes which are scattered abroad" (James 1:1). The apostles never stopped recognizing Israel as Israel.

Partakers, Not Replacements

The word Paul uses for what has happened to the Gentiles is *partakers*. He wrote to the Ephesians "That the Gentiles should be fellowheirs, and of the same body, and partakers of his promise in Christ by the gospel" (Eph. 3:6). A partaker is one who shares in something with others; he takes part in what belongs to another. Gentile believers have been given a share in promises that were first made to Israel. That is grace. It is not a transfer of title.

Paul calls this a mystery, "Which in other ages was not made known unto the sons of men, as it is now revealed unto his holy apostles and prophets by the Spirit" (Eph. 3:5). The Old Testament prophets saw the Gentiles blessed through Israel, but they did not see one body in which Jew and Gentile would be joined together in this age. It was hidden in ages past and revealed to the apostles. We now have that revelation written down in a completed Bible, and it is there for anyone who will study to show himself approved. Even the apostles had to work through it. Peter had to be corrected on this very matter (Gal. 2:11–14), and Paul spent chapters explaining it. It should not

surprise us that people still stumble over it today, and it should humble anyone who thinks the church has left Israel behind. The mystery is that we were brought in. It is not that they were thrown out.

ROMANS 9: ISRAEL'S PAST

Romans 9, 10, and 11 belong together. They are often summed up this way: chapter 9 is Israel's past, chapter 10 is Israel's present, and chapter 11 is Israel's future. After eight chapters on the gospel of God's righteousness, Paul turns to a question every Jewish reader would ask: if the gospel is true, and most of Israel has rejected it, has the word of God failed? These three chapters are his answer. They are also where replacement theology plays its most confusing game with words.

Paul's Kinsmen

Paul begins with personal grief.

Romans 9:1–5

"I say the truth in Christ, I lie not, my conscience also bearing me witness in the Holy Ghost, That I have great heaviness and continual sorrow in my heart. For I could wish that myself were accursed from Christ for my brethren, my kinsmen according to the flesh: Who are Israelites; to whom pertaineth the adoption, and the glory, and the covenants, and the giving of the law, and the service of God, and the promises; Whose are the fathers, and of whom as concerning the flesh Christ came, who is over all, God blessed for ever. Amen."

Paul could hardly have been more specific. These are his "kinsmen according to the flesh." They are "Israelites." To them "pertaineth" the covenants and the promises. Paul does not say those things once pertained to them. He uses the present tense. And these are unbelieving Israelites, the very people for whom he grieves because they are lost. Paul's heart for them is so great that he could wish himself cut off from Christ for their sake. He would not speak that way about a nation God had discarded.

It is also important to recall why Christ came. "For the Son of man is come to seek and to save that which was lost" (Luke 19:10), he said, standing in the house of a man he had just called "a son of Abraham" (Luke 19:9). He told a Gentile woman, "I am not sent but unto the lost sheep of the house of Israel" (Matt.

15:24). He came to Israel as their Messiah and King, offering the kingdom promised to them. They did not receive him, and he went to the cross, which was God's plan all along. But it was to Israel that he came.

They Are Not All Israel

Then comes the verse that replacement teachers love: "Not as though the word of God hath taken none effect. For they are not all Israel, which are of Israel: Neither, because they are the seed of Abraham, are they all children: but, In Isaac shall thy seed be called" (Rom. 9:6–7). Replacement teachers often cite this verse as evidence that the word Israel now refers to the church.

But look at what Paul is actually doing. He is distinguishing between two groups within Israel: the whole nation descended from Jacob, and the believing remnant inside it. "They are not all Israel, which are of Israel" means that not every physical Israelite is a true child of the promise by faith. It does not mean Gentiles are Israel. Every example he gives is inside Abraham's family. Isaac and Ishmael were both sons of Abraham, but the promise ran through Isaac. Jacob and Esau were both sons of Isaac, but the promise ran through Jacob.

The replacement reading can be tested by applying it consistently through the chapter. In verse 4, are the "Israelites" to whom pertain the giving of the law the church? The law was given at Sinai to physical Israel. In chapter 10 verse 1, Paul prays "for Israel… that they might be saved." Does the church need to be saved? In chapter 11 verse 1 he says, "I also am an Israelite, of the seed of Abraham, of the tribe of Benjamin." Is Benjamin a tribe of the church? Once you make Israel mean the church in one verse, you have to switch it back in the next, and back again after that. It does not make sense, because it is not what Paul meant.

Jacob and Esau

Paul continues with Jacob and Esau: "As it is written, Jacob have I loved, but Esau have I hated" (Rom. 9:13). Many read that as a

statement about two individuals and their eternal destinies. But Paul tells us where he is quoting from, "as it is written," and we are allowed to go look. The source is Malachi 1.

Malachi 1:1–4

"The burden of the word of the LORD to Israel by Malachi. I have loved you, saith the LORD. Yet ye say, Wherein hast thou loved us? Was not Esau Jacob's brother? saith the LORD: yet I loved Jacob, And I hated Esau, and laid his mountains and his heritage waste for the dragons of the wilderness. Whereas Edom saith, We are impoverished, but we will return and build the desolate places; thus saith the LORD of hosts, They shall build, but I will throw down; and they shall call them, The border of wickedness, and, The people against whom the LORD hath indignation for ever."

Malachi is speaking of nations. Esau is Edom, "the people against whom the LORD hath indignation." Genesis says so again and again: "Therefore was his name called Edom" (Gen. 25:30); "Now these are the generations of Esau, who is Edom" (Gen. 36:1); "Esau is Edom" (Gen. 36:8). And Jacob is Israel. Before the twins were born God told their mother, "Two nations are in thy womb" (Gen. 25:23). Romans 9 is not about God choosing one baby for heaven and the other for hell. It is about God choosing the nation through which he would work.

Edom lay to the south and southeast of the Dead Sea, around Mount Seir, in what is now southern Jordan. Its long hostility toward Israel runs through the prophets, and the whole short book of Obadiah is devoted to it. That national conflict is the backdrop of Malachi 1, and therefore of Romans 9.

The word *hated* also deserves care. In the Bible it often means to love less, or to set aside in favor of another. When Jacob married Leah and Rachel, the Bible says "he loved also Rachel more than Leah," and in the next verse, "the LORD saw that Leah was hated" (Gen. 29:30–31). Jacob did not despise Leah; he loved her less. The Lord Jesus said, "If any man come to me, and hate not his father, and mother… he cannot be my disciple" (Luke 14:26),

and the parallel passage explains it: "He that loveth father or mother more than me is not worthy of me" (Matt. 10:37). Hate, in these places, is a comparison of love.

Why Jacob?

Even at the personal level, the account of Jacob and Esau is clear. Jacob was far from perfect. He was a deceiver. But when Esau came in from the field hungry, Jacob saw value in something no one could see or touch: the birthright and the blessing God had promised to Abraham's family. Esau traded it for a bowl of red pottage. "Thus Esau despised his birthright" (Gen. 25:34). Hebrews calls him a "profane person… who for one morsel of meat sold his birthright" (Heb. 12:16). Esau is the picture of the carnal man who values what satisfies the flesh right now. Jacob, for all his faults, is the picture of the man who values God's promise.

Even so, Esau's story does not end in hatred. When Jacob returned years later, terrified that his brother would kill him, "Esau ran to meet him, and embraced him, and fell on his neck, and kissed him: and they wept" (Gen. 33:4). The national conflict between Israel and Edom is real, but Genesis shows us two brothers, and the prophets show us that God has not forgotten either nation's history.

Romans 9 therefore concerns Israel's past: God chose the nation of Israel through Isaac and Jacob for his purposes, and within that nation there has always been a believing remnant and an unbelieving majority. None of that makes the church Israel. It explains why most of Israel's rejection of Christ does not mean the word of God has failed. It never promised that every Israelite would be saved simply because he was an Israelite.

ROMANS 10: ISRAEL'S PRESENT

If chapter 9 looks back at how God chose and dealt with Israel, chapter 10 describes where Israel stands now. And it opens with a sentence that ought to end the debate over what Paul means by Israel: "Brethren, my heart's desire and prayer to God for Israel is, that they might be saved" (Rom. 10:1).

The church does not need to be saved; it is made up of people who already are. Paul is praying for the nation of Israel, his unbelieving kinsmen. Everything that follows in the chapter is about them.

Romans 10:2–4

"For I bear them record that they have a zeal of God, but not according to knowledge. For they being ignorant of God's righteousness, and going about to establish their own righteousness, have not submitted themselves unto the righteousness of God. For Christ is the end of the law for righteousness to every one that believeth."

That describes Israel today as accurately as it described Israel in Paul's day. They have a zeal of God. Many of them are deeply devoted to the law and the traditions. But they have not submitted to the righteousness of God that comes through faith in Jesus Christ. Paul then speaks to them in terms they would know: "For Moses describeth the righteousness which is of the law" (Rom. 10:5). Gentile converts in Rome would hardly have needed Moses explained to them in this way. Paul is reasoning with Israel from Israel's own Scriptures.

The Greatest Salvation Verses Were Written About Israel

It is significant that the clearest verses in the Bible on how a person is saved sit right in the middle of Paul's argument about Israel. "That if thou shalt confess with thy mouth the Lord Jesus, and shalt believe in thine heart that God hath raised him from the dead, thou shalt be saved" (Rom. 10:9). "For whosoever shall call upon the name of the Lord shall be saved" (Rom. 10:13). We rightly use those verses with anyone who asks how to be saved.

But in context Paul wrote them because he wanted Israel to be saved. Jews are saved exactly the same way Gentiles are: by calling on the Lord Jesus in faith. "For there is no difference between the Jew and the Greek: for the same Lord over all is rich unto all that call upon him" (Rom. 10:12).

This is why God's national plan for Israel does not mean an individual Jew can reach heaven apart from Christ. No one taught in this book believes that. An Israeli who rejects Christ and opposes Christians is lost and needs the gospel as surely as anyone else. God has not promised to save Israel in their unbelief. He has promised to bring the nation to faith.

A More Sure Word

Paul goes on:

Romans 10:6–8

"But the righteousness which is of faith speaketh on this wise, Say not in thine heart, Who shall ascend into heaven? (that is, to bring Christ down from above:) Or, Who shall descend into the deep? (that is, to bring up Christ again from the dead.) But what saith it? The word is nigh thee, even in thy mouth, and in thy heart: that is, the word of faith, which we preach."

"The Jews require a sign," Paul wrote elsewhere (1 Cor. 1:22), and throughout their history God gave them signs. The apostles went forth preaching, "the Lord working with them, and confirming the word with signs following" (Mark 16:20). But Paul tells Israel here that they do not need a new miracle. The word is near them. Peter, who saw the Lord transfigured and heard the Father's voice from heaven, said that the written word was even more certain than what he had seen and heard: "We have also a more sure word of prophecy; whereunto ye do well that ye take heed" (2 Pet. 1:19).

The Lord made the same point in the account of the rich man and Lazarus. When the rich man begged that someone be sent from the dead to warn his brothers, Abraham answered, "If they

hear not Moses and the prophets, neither will they be persuaded, though one rose from the dead" (Luke 16:31). Then Christ rose from the dead, exactly as he said, and multitudes still did not believe. Signs do not produce faith in a heart that rejects the word. "So then faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God" (Rom. 10:17). Israel's present condition is unbelief, but the remedy is in their hands. It is the same remedy that is in ours.

Have They Not Heard?

The chapter ends by answering the objection that Israel may simply never have heard. "How then shall they call on him in whom they have not believed? and how shall they believe in him of whom they have not heard? and how shall they hear without a preacher?" (Rom. 10:14). Paul answers: "But I say, Have they not heard? Yes verily, their sound went into all the earth, and their words unto the ends of the world" (Rom. 10:18). Israel heard. Their problem was not ignorance but unbelief.

Then Paul quotes Moses to show that God had foreseen this and had a plan for it: "But I say, Did not Israel know? First Moses saith, I will provoke you to jealousy by them that are no people, and by a foolish nation I will anger you" (Rom. 10:19). The Gentiles are the "no people" and the "foolish nation." God is using the salvation of the Gentiles to provoke Israel to jealousy, and you only try to make someone jealous if you want them back.

The last verse of the chapter is one of the most tender in the Bible: "But to Israel he saith, All day long I have stretched forth my hands unto a disobedient and gainsaying people" (Rom. 10:21). That is Israel's present condition: disobedient and gainsaying. And that is God's present posture toward them: hands stretched out all day long. He has not turned his back on them. A God who had replaced Israel would not be described this way in the chapter about Israel's present.

ROMANS 11: ISRAEL'S FUTURE

Romans 11 is the key to this whole subject. If chapter 9 is Israel's past and chapter 10 is Israel's present, chapter 11 is Israel's future, and Paul leaves no doubt that Israel has one.

Hath God Cast Away His People?

"I say then, Hath God cast away his people? God forbid. For I also am an Israelite, of the seed of Abraham, of the tribe of Benjamin. God hath not cast away his people which he foreknew" (Rom. 11:1–2).

That is the question of this entire book, and Paul answers it in two words: God forbid. Those who hold the replacement view say that "his people" here means the elect or the church. But Paul immediately tells us whom he means by identifying himself: an Israelite, of the seed of Abraham, of the tribe of Benjamin. He could not have been more specific. When you refuse to take the Bible for what it says, you lose the ability to read it specifically. Every detail must become a symbol of something else, and the reader becomes his own authority, deciding when Israel means Israel and when it does not.

The word *elect* is often part of this confusion. The Bible does call the church elect (Col. 3:12). It also calls Israel God's elect: "For Jacob my servant's sake, and Israel mine elect" (Isa. 45:4). It even speaks of "the elect angels" (1 Tim. 5:21). The context has to tell us which elect is meant. In Romans 11 the context could not be clearer.

A Remnant Now, a Nation Later

Paul then gives a second proof that God has not cast away his people. In Elijah's day, the prophet thought he was the only faithful Israelite left. "But what saith the answer of God unto him? I have reserved to myself seven thousand men, who have not bowed the knee to the image of Baal. Even so then at this present time also there is a remnant according to the election of grace" (Rom. 11:4–5). In every age, including this one, God has

kept a believing remnant in Israel. Paul himself was part of it. Every Jewish person who trusts Christ today is part of it. The existence of that remnant is proof that God is still working with Israel.

But a remnant is not the end of the story.

Romans 11:11–12

"I say then, Have they stumbled that they should fall? God forbid: but rather through their fall salvation is come unto the Gentiles, for to provoke them to jealousy. Now if the fall of them be the riches of the world, and the diminishing of them the riches of the Gentiles; how much more their fulness?"

Israel stumbled, but they did not fall beyond recovery. Their stumbling has become the Gentiles' blessing. And Paul looks ahead to "their fulness," a day when not just a remnant but the nation will be restored. If Israel's fall enriched the world, their fulness will enrich it far more.

The Olive Tree

Paul then turns to the Gentiles directly. "For I speak to you Gentiles, inasmuch as I am the apostle of the Gentiles, I magnify mine office: If by any means I may provoke to emulation them which are my flesh, and might save some of them" (Rom. 11:13–14). Then he gives the picture of the olive tree:

Romans 11:17–21

"And if some of the branches be broken off, and thou, being a wild olive tree, wert graffed in among them, and with them partakest of the root and fatness of the olive tree; Boast not against the branches. But if thou boast, thou bearest not the root, but the root thee. Thou wilt say then, The branches were broken off, that I might be graffed in. Well; because of unbelief they were broken off, and thou standest by faith. Be not highminded, but fear: For if God spared not the natural branches, take heed lest he also spare not thee."

Several things in this passage are fatal to replacement theology.

First, there is one tree, not two. The Gentiles were "graffed in among them." They did not plant a new tree to replace the old one. They were grafted into Israel's tree and partake "with them" of its root and fatness. To replace Israel, God would have had to cut down the tree and plant another, and he did not do so.

Second, Paul says "some of the branches" were broken off, not all. There has always been a believing remnant in Israel. The apostles were Jews. The three thousand at Pentecost were Jews. There are believing Jews today.

Third, the natural branches are Israel, and the wild branches are Gentiles. Paul calls the Gentiles' grafting "contrary to nature" (Rom. 11:24). We are the unnatural ones in this picture, not them. That should humble any Gentile believer.

Fourth, God is able to graft Israel back in:

Romans 11:23–24

"And they also, if they abide not still in unbelief, shall be graffed in: for God is able to graff them in again. For if thou wert cut out of the olive tree which is wild by nature, and wert graffed contrary to nature into a good olive tree: how much more shall these, which be the natural branches, be graffed into their own olive tree?"

If the church were Israel, into what tree would Israel be grafted back? It is *their own* olive tree.

Boast Not

The warning against boasting is aimed squarely at Gentile believers who think God has finished with Israel. "Boast not against the branches… Be not highminded, but fear." God knew this attitude would arise. The claim that the church has inherited Abraham's promises and that God is finished with Israel is precisely the boasting Paul forbids. And he attaches a warning: "For if God spared not the natural branches, take heed lest he also spare not thee."

The same words appear together in another passage about the last days: "For men shall be lovers of their own selves, covetous, boasters, proud, blasphemers… Traitors, heady, highminded" (2 Tim. 3:2, 4). Boasting and high-mindedness are marks of the perilous times. It is a sobering thing to find them attached to the attitude God warns against in Romans 11.

And So All Israel Shall Be Saved

Then Paul reveals the mystery:

Romans 11:25–27

"For I would not, brethren, that ye should be ignorant of this mystery, lest ye should be wise in your own conceits; that blindness in part is happened to Israel, until the fulness of the Gentiles be come in. And so all Israel shall be saved: as it is written, There shall come out of Sion the Deliverer, and shall turn away ungodliness from Jacob: For this is my covenant unto them, when I shall take away their sins."

Israel's blindness is "in part," not total, and it is temporary, "until the fulness of the Gentiles be come in." After that, "all Israel shall be saved." Who is this Israel? Paul answers from Isaiah: the Deliverer "shall turn away ungodliness from Jacob." Jacob is the father of the twelve tribes. The quotation comes from Isaiah 59, where the covenant is with Jacob's seed:

Isaiah 59:20–21

"And the Redeemer shall come to Zion, and unto them that turn from transgression in Jacob, saith the LORD. As for me, this is my covenant with them, saith the LORD; My spirit that is upon thee, and my words which I have put in thy mouth, shall not depart out of thy mouth, nor out of the mouth of thy seed, nor out of the mouth of thy seed's seed, saith the LORD, from henceforth and for ever."

The church did not exist when Isaiah wrote. He was speaking of Israel.

Yet this is the very place where the replacement view switches the meaning of Israel one more time. John Calvin wrote on this

verse, "I extend the word Israel to all the people of God."[3] Many who follow him say the same. But in the verse right before it, Israel is the nation that is blinded in part until the Gentiles come in. The church is not blinded until the Gentiles come in. The church is made up largely of those Gentiles. The meaning of Israel cannot change between verse 25 and verse 26.

Paul adds one more line that settles the matter: "As concerning the gospel, they are enemies for your sakes: but as touching the election, they are beloved for the fathers' sakes. For the gifts and calling of God are without repentance" (Rom. 11:28–29). Israel is at once an enemy of the gospel and beloved for the fathers' sake. God does not take back his gifts or revoke his calling. That is why Israel still has a future.

Paul closes the chapter in worship: "O the depth of the riches both of the wisdom and knowledge of God! how unsearchable are his judgments, and his ways past finding out!" (Rom. 11:33). The man who thinks the church has replaced Israel has not yet seen the depth of those riches. God's faithfulness to a people who have so often been unfaithful to him is one of the brightest displays of his grace in all of Scripture.

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[3]John Calvin, *Commentaries on the Epistle of Paul the Apostle to the Romans*, trans. and ed. John Owen (Edinburgh: Calvin Translation Society, 1849), comment on Rom. 11:26. In fairness, Calvin did expect that "the Jews also shall return from their defection to the obedience of faith," but he made "all Israel" in this verse mean the whole people of God gathered from Jews and Gentiles.

THE NEW COVENANT BELONGS TO ISRAEL

One of the strongest arguments replacement teachers make goes like this: the church is under the new covenant; the new covenant replaced the old; therefore the church has replaced Israel. It sounds persuasive until we read the new covenant itself and ask to whom it was made.

The Promise in Jeremiah

Jeremiah 31:31–33

"Behold, the days come, saith the LORD, that I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel, and with the house of Judah: Not according to the covenant that I made with their fathers in the day that I took them by the hand to bring them out of the land of Egypt; which my covenant they brake, although I was an husband unto them, saith the LORD: But this shall be the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel; After those days, saith the LORD, I will put my law in their inward parts, and write it in their hearts; and will be their God, and they shall be my people."

The new covenant was made "with the house of Israel, and with the house of Judah." Both houses are named, the northern tribes and the southern kingdom. It was not made with the church, which did not yet exist, and it was not made with the Gentiles. It replaces the covenant God made "with their fathers" at the exodus, which is the law of Moses. It does not replace the covenant with Abraham, and it does not replace Israel. It is the promise that God will one day give Israel what the law could never give them: a new heart.

And look at what immediately follows.

Jeremiah 31:35–37

"Thus saith the LORD, which giveth the sun for a light by day, and the ordinances of the moon and of the stars for a light by night… If those ordinances depart from before me, saith the LORD, then the seed of Israel also shall cease from being a nation before me for ever. Thus saith

the LORD; If heaven above can be measured, and the foundations of the earth searched out beneath, I will also cast off all the seed of Israel for all that they have done, saith the LORD."

God attached a guarantee to the new covenant. Before anyone could say that Israel's sin had cancelled it, he said: measure heaven first. The same chapter that promises the new covenant promises that God will never cast off the seed of Israel "for all that they have done."

The Book of Hebrews Quotes It

Hebrews quotes Jeremiah 31 in full, and it does not change the recipients: "For finding fault with them, he saith, Behold, the days come, saith the Lord, when I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and with the house of Judah" (Heb. 8:8). The writer was addressing Hebrew believers, and he made no attempt to redefine Israel and Judah. His point was that the new covenant was always God's plan and that Christ is its mediator.

Gentile believers share in it through the blood of Christ. At the Last Supper the Lord took the cup and said, "This cup is the new testament in my blood, which is shed for you" (Luke 22:20). The blood that will one day secure Israel's new heart has already been shed, and every believer in this age is washed in it. Paul called himself and his fellow workers "able ministers of the new testament; not of the letter, but of the spirit" (2 Cor. 3:6). We enjoy the spiritual blessings of the new covenant now: forgiveness of sins, the indwelling Spirit, a new heart. This is what Paul meant when he told the Gentiles they had been made "partakers of his promise in Christ by the gospel" (Eph. 3:6).

The National Fulfillment Is Still Future

But Jeremiah's promise includes more than individual forgiveness. It says, "they shall teach no more every man his neighbour, and every man his brother, saying, Know the LORD: for they shall all know me, from the least of them unto the greatest of them" (Jer. 31:34). No one can say that is true of Israel today, or of the professing church either. There is still a need to

teach our neighbors to know the Lord. The national side of the new covenant, a whole nation of Israel knowing the Lord from the least to the greatest, is still future.

Paul says exactly that in Romans 11. After "all Israel shall be saved," he quotes the prophets: "For this is my covenant unto them, when I shall take away their sins" (Rom. 11:27). The covenant in view is the one Jeremiah promised, in which God says, "I will forgive their iniquity, and I will remember their sin no more" (Jer. 31:34). Paul places the fulfillment of that covenant with Israel at the end of the times of the Gentiles, when the Deliverer comes out of Zion. The church has entered the blessings of the new covenant ahead of time, by grace. Israel will enter them as a nation when the Lord returns.

The new covenant, therefore, does not show that the church replaced Israel; it shows the opposite. It was made with Israel and Judah. It is guaranteed by the ordinances of heaven. The church partakes of it through the blood of Christ, and Israel will yet receive it in full. A Gentile believer who enjoys forgiveness under the new covenant is enjoying a promise first spoken to the Jewish people. That should make us grateful, not boastful. As Paul put it, "For if the Gentiles have been made partakers of their spiritual things, their duty is also to minister unto them in carnal things" (Rom. 15:27). We are debtors to Israel. We did not take their place.

OTHER PASSAGES USED TO REPLACE ISRAEL

Besides Romans 2, Galatians 3, and Romans 9, a handful of other verses are regularly used to argue that the church is now Israel. None of them is difficult when it is read in its setting. Each deserves an answer, because each is presented as if it settled the matter.

"The Kingdom of God Shall Be Taken from You"

After the parable of the wicked husbandmen, the Lord said, "Therefore say I unto you, The kingdom of God shall be taken from you, and given to a nation bringing forth the fruits thereof" (Matt. 21:43). Here, many say, is the moment Israel was replaced.

But look at the next verse: "And when the chief priests and Pharisees had heard his parables, they perceived that he spake of them" (Matt. 21:45). The "you" was the leadership that was rejecting him, the husbandmen who had been put in charge of the vineyard and were about to kill the heir. The vineyard itself, in Isaiah's song that the parable echoes, is "the house of Israel" (Isa. 5:7). The husbandmen were replaced; the vineyard was not destroyed. And the Lord had just told those same leaders that Jerusalem would not see him again until they said, "Blessed is he that cometh in the name of the Lord" (Matt. 23:39). The nation that will bring forth the fruits is Israel itself, repentant and restored, the nation of whom God says, "they shall all know me." Until then, the kingdom's message has gone out to the Gentiles, and the church is bearing fruit for God in this age. None of that makes the church Israel.

"The Israel of God"

Paul ends Galatians with a blessing: "For in Christ Jesus neither circumcision availeth any thing, nor uncircumcision, but a new creature. And as many as walk according to this rule, peace be on them, and mercy, and upon the Israel of God" (Gal. 6:15–16). Replacement teachers say "the Israel of God" is the whole church, Jew and Gentile together.

The sentence should be read carefully. Paul pronounces peace and mercy on "as many as walk according to this rule," and then "upon the Israel of God." The word *and* adds a second group. The whole letter has been a battle with Jewish teachers who wanted to circumcise the Gentiles. At its close Paul blesses all who walk by grace, and then he specifically blesses the Jews who had believed the gospel and refused the circumcision party: the true Israel of God, the believing remnant within Israel that he describes in Romans 9:6 and 11:5. It is the only place in the New Testament where anyone suggests the phrase means the church, and it does not have to mean that. The word *Israel* appears seventy-five times in the New Testament (eighteen of them in Paul's letters), and outside this one verse no one seriously argues that it means Gentiles. One disputed verse cannot overturn all the rest.

"One New Man"

Ephesians 2 tells the Gentile believers that they were once "aliens from the commonwealth of Israel, and strangers from the covenants of promise, having no hope, and without God in the world" (Eph. 2:12). Now, through the cross, Christ has made "in himself of twain one new man, so making peace" (Eph. 2:15). And "Now therefore ye are no more strangers and foreigners, but fellowcitizens with the saints, and of the household of God" (Eph. 2:19).

The argument is that Gentiles have been brought into Israel. But that is not what Paul says. He says Jew and Gentile have been made into *one new man*. If Gentiles had simply become Israelites, Paul would have said so, and the man would not be new. The body of Christ is something that did not exist before, which is why Paul calls it a mystery in the next chapter. Gentile believers are fellow citizens "with the saints" and members of "the household of God." They are not Israelites. The church is neither Jew nor Gentile in Christ. This is why the church cannot be the Israel of the prophets, which is always a nation with tribes, a land, and a throne.

"We Are the Circumcision"

Paul wrote to the Philippians, "For we are the circumcision, which worship God in the spirit, and rejoice in Christ Jesus, and have no confidence in the flesh" (Phil. 3:3). The context is a warning against the same Judaizers: "Beware of dogs, beware of evil workers, beware of the concision" (Phil. 3:2). Paul is contrasting true, heart circumcision with a merely physical cutting that some were trusting in for salvation. It is the Romans 2 principle again: personal standing with God is a matter of the heart. In the very next verses Paul describes himself as "of the stock of Israel, of the tribe of Benjamin, an Hebrew of the Hebrews" (Phil. 3:5). He never stopped being an Israelite in the national sense, even while he counted all his fleshly advantages as loss for Christ.

"An Holy Nation"

Peter calls believers "a chosen generation, a royal priesthood, an holy nation, a peculiar people" (1 Pet. 2:9). These are Israel's titles from Sinai: "ye shall be unto me a kingdom of priests, and an holy nation" (Exod. 19:6). So, the argument goes, the church now holds Israel's identity.

Peter's letter is addressed "to the strangers scattered throughout Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia" (1 Pet. 1:1). The word for scattered is the word for the Jewish dispersion, and Peter was the apostle of the circumcision (Gal. 2:7). Many of his readers were Jewish believers, the remnant of Israel who had believed on the Messiah, and it would be natural for him to say that they were what God had always called Israel to be. But even if Peter is including Gentile believers, applying Israel's titles to the church is not the same as transferring Israel's promises. God can describe his people in this age with the language of Sinai without cancelling what he swore to Abraham. Peter himself, in his sermon in Acts 3, told the men of Israel that they were "the children of the prophets, and of the covenant which God made with our fathers" (Acts 3:25), and that heaven would receive Christ "until the times of restitution of all things, which God

hath spoken by the mouth of all his holy prophets" (Acts 3:21). Peter did not believe Israel's future had been cancelled.

"Ready to Vanish Away"

Hebrews says of the old covenant, "In that he saith, A new covenant, he hath made the first old. Now that which decayeth and waxeth old is ready to vanish away" (Heb. 8:13). This is sometimes offered as proof that Israel itself has passed away. But the covenant that is ready to vanish is the Mosaic covenant, the law that the new covenant replaces. The chapter quotes the new covenant as made "with the house of Israel and with the house of Judah" (Heb. 8:8). The passing of the law is not the passing of Israel. It is the preparation for Israel's new heart.

Two Groups in the Holy City

Finally, look at the very end of the Bible. New Jerusalem has twelve gates, "and names written thereon, which are the names of the twelve tribes of the children of Israel" (Rev. 21:12). It also has twelve foundations, "and in them the names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb" (Rev. 21:14). Even in eternity, God distinguishes the tribes of Israel from the apostles of the church. He does not melt them into one. If the church had replaced Israel, there would be no reason to write the tribes on the gates.

Each of these passages, read in its own setting, says something true and precious about the church. None of them says the church is Israel. And against these few disputed verses stand the hundreds of plain promises in the prophets, the covenant with Abraham, the oath to David, the new covenant made with Israel and Judah, and Paul's own "God forbid" in Romans 11:1. The clear must interpret the unclear, not the other way around.

The Word Israel in the New Testament

A final observation places these passages in perspective. By our count, the word *Israel* appears seventy-five times in seventy-three verses of the King James New Testament. In the great majority of these, no one disputes that it refers to the nation or

people descended from Jacob: "the lost sheep of the house of Israel" (Matt. 10:6), "the consolation of Israel" (Luke 2:25), "the hope of Israel" (Acts 28:20), "the twelve tribes of Israel" (Matt. 19:28), and many others. Replacement teaching rests its case on a very small number of verses, chiefly Romans 9:6 and Galatians 6:16, and even these, as we have seen, are best read as referring to believing Jews within Israel. When a word has one clear meaning in more than seventy places, the burden of proof lies on the reader who claims that it means something entirely different in one or two.

WHAT THE LORD JESUS AND THE APOSTLES TAUGHT

Replacement teachers often say that the Old Testament must be read through the lens of the New, and that once we do, we will see that the New Testament reinterprets Israel as the church. The question, then, is what the Lord Jesus and his apostles actually said about Israel's future. If they had set the promises aside, we would expect them to say so. Instead, they affirmed them.

Twelve Thrones

When Peter asked what the disciples would receive for leaving everything to follow him, the Lord answered, "Verily I say unto you, That ye which have followed me, in the regeneration when the Son of man shall sit in the throne of his glory, ye also shall sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel" (Matt. 19:28). He repeated it at the last supper: "that ye may eat and drink at my table in my kingdom, and sit on thrones judging the twelve tribes of Israel" (Luke 22:30).

The twelve tribes of Israel will exist in the kingdom, and the apostles will judge them. The apostles are not the tribes, and the tribes are not the church. The Lord kept the two distinct even as he promised both a future.

Until the Times of the Gentiles

In the Olivet Discourse the Lord foretold Jerusalem's destruction and the scattering of the Jews: "And they shall fall by the edge of the sword, and shall be led away captive into all nations: and Jerusalem shall be trodden down of the Gentiles, until the times of the Gentiles be fulfilled" (Luke 21:24). The key word is *until*. Jerusalem's treading down has a limit. When the times of the Gentiles are fulfilled, Jerusalem's condition will change. Paul used the same kind of boundary for Israel's blindness: "blindness in part is happened to Israel, until the fulness of the Gentiles be come in" (Rom. 11:25). The Lord and his apostle both set an end date on Israel's present condition. A condition with an end date is not a permanent rejection.

Times of Refreshing

After Pentecost, Peter preached in the temple to a crowd he addressed as "Ye men of Israel" (Acts 3:12). He told them they had killed the Prince of life, and then he made them this offer:

Acts 3:19–21

"Repent ye therefore, and be converted, that your sins may be blotted out, when the times of refreshing shall come from the presence of the Lord; And he shall send Jesus Christ, which before was preached unto you: Whom the heaven must receive until the times of restitution of all things, which God hath spoken by the mouth of all his holy prophets since the world began."

Peter tied the Lord's return to "the times of restitution of all things" that "all his holy prophets" had spoken of. Those prophets spoke of Israel regathered, David's throne restored, and the land made fruitful. Peter did not reinterpret them. He pointed his Jewish hearers to them as still future, waiting on the Lord's return and the nation's repentance.

A Minister of the Circumcision

Paul, the apostle to the Gentiles, told the Romans plainly why Christ came: "Now I say that Jesus Christ was a minister of the circumcision for the truth of God, to confirm the promises made unto the fathers: And that the Gentiles might glorify God for his mercy" (Rom. 15:8–9). Christ came to *confirm* the promises made to the fathers, not to cancel them. The Gentiles glorify God for his mercy; Israel receives the truth of God, his faithfulness to his word.

The Lord said the same thing to the Samaritan woman at the well: "Ye worship ye know not what: we know what we worship: for salvation is of the Jews" (John 4:22). He did not say that salvation had once been of the Jews; he said that it is.

Put these passages together: twelve tribes judged in the kingdom, Jerusalem trodden down only until a set time, a restitution of all things that the prophets foretold, and a Messiah

who came to confirm the promises made to the fathers. That is what the New Testament says about Israel. It does not reinterpret the promises; it confirms them.

ISRAEL IN THE LAST DAYS

The prophets say a great deal about Israel in the end times. These passages cannot be set aside without either ignoring large portions of the Old Testament or treating them as symbolic. Read as written, they present a consistent picture: after God finishes his work among the Gentiles in this age, he turns again to Israel.

The Time of Jacob's Trouble

The coming tribulation is called by Jeremiah "the time of Jacob's trouble": "Alas! for that day is great, so that none is like it: it is even the time of Jacob's trouble; but he shall be saved out of it" (Jer. 30:7). God will pour out judgment on the whole earth in that day, but the tribulation has a purpose. It is the time when God deals with the nation of Israel and brings them to himself.

Daniel's prophecy of the seventy weeks begins, "Seventy weeks are determined upon thy people and upon thy holy city" (Dan. 9:24). Daniel's people were the Jews, and his holy city was Jerusalem. The last of those weeks is still future, and in the midst of it comes the abomination of desolation, which the Lord Jesus told his Jewish disciples to watch for: "When ye therefore shall see the abomination of desolation, spoken of by Daniel the prophet, stand in the holy place… Then let them which be in Judaea flee into the mountains" (Matt. 24:15–16). The Olivet Discourse is full of Judea, the sabbath, and the holy place, because it concerns Israel. The Babylonian captivity of seventy years, which drove Daniel to his knees in the first place (Dan. 9:2), was itself a smaller picture of the greater tribulation to come.

The Tribes, the Woman, and the Brethren

In Revelation 7, God seals "an hundred and forty and four thousand of all the tribes of the children of Israel" (Rev. 7:4), and then names the tribes one by one, twelve thousand from each. The tribes would hardly be named individually if they had no

meaning. When pressed, those who make these verses symbolic often admit they do not know what the tribes are symbolic of. The church has no tribes; Israel does.

In Revelation 12 a woman appears "clothed with the sun, and the moon under her feet, and upon her head a crown of twelve stars" (Rev. 12:1). That picture comes from Joseph's dream, where the sun, moon, and stars were Jacob, his wife, and the twelve sons of Israel (Gen. 37:9–10). The woman is Israel, the nation from which the Christ came, and the dragon's rage against her and "the remnant of her seed" (Rev. 12:17) is the story of Satan's hatred of Israel carried to its climax.

It is also worth noticing that after the letters to the seven churches in Revelation 2 and 3, the church is not seen on earth through the judgments of the tribulation. The word *church* does not appear again until the closing message of the book (Rev. 22:16). John is caught up to heaven at the start of chapter 4 (Rev. 4:1), and many see in that a picture of the catching away of the church described in 1 Thessalonians 4:16–17. When the church is gone, God's attention returns to Israel.

The Lord's judgment of the nations in Matthew 25 fits the same pattern. When the Son of man sits on the throne of his glory and separates the sheep from the goats, the standard is how they treated "these my brethren" (Matt. 25:40). In the context of the tribulation he has just described, his brethren are the Jewish people. God takes the treatment of Israel so seriously that it becomes the measure by which the nations are judged.

The book of Revelation is full of Israel in the same way. In chapter 11 John is told, "Rise, and measure the temple of God, and the altar, and them that worship therein. But the court which is without the temple leave out, and measure it not; for it is given unto the Gentiles: and the holy city shall they tread under foot forty and two months" (Rev. 11:1–2). A temple, an altar, worshippers, and a holy city trodden down by Gentiles. The two witnesses of that chapter die "in the street of the great city, which spiritually is called Sodom and Egypt, where also our

Lord was crucified" (Rev. 11:8). That city is Jerusalem. The tribulation takes place in the land of Israel, around the city of Jerusalem, and it concerns the Jewish people. It cannot be read as a picture of the church without losing every detail God put there.

Not for Your Sakes

Before the valley of dry bones comes Ezekiel 36, and it explains why God will restore Israel at all. It is not because they deserve it. "Therefore say unto the house of Israel, Thus saith the Lord GOD; I do not this for your sakes, O house of Israel, but for mine holy name's sake, which ye have profaned among the heathen, whither ye went" (Ezek. 36:22). God's own name is at stake. He promised, and the nations are watching to see whether he keeps his word.

Then comes the order of events: "For I will take you from among the heathen, and gather you out of all countries, and will bring you into your own land" (Ezek. 36:24). After that, "Then will I sprinkle clean water upon you, and ye shall be clean" (Ezek. 36:25), and "A new heart also will I give you, and a new spirit will I put within you: and I will take away the stony heart out of your flesh, and I will give you an heart of flesh" (Ezek. 36:26). Finally, "ye shall dwell in the land that I gave to your fathers; and ye shall be my people, and I will be your God" (Ezek. 36:28). First the land, then the cleansing and the new heart. The regathering comes before the conversion. This is the order the next chapter pictures with bones, flesh, and breath.

The Valley of Dry Bones

The most vivid picture of Israel's future is Ezekiel 37. The prophet is set down in a valley full of bones, "and, lo, they were very dry" (Ezek. 37:2). It is the most hopeless scene imaginable, not just death but long death, bones scattered and bleached in a low place. God asks, "Son of man, can these bones live?" (Ezek. 37:3), and then commands Ezekiel to prophesy to them.

What happens next comes in two stages. First, "there was a noise, and behold a shaking, and the bones came together, bone to his bone. And when I beheld, lo, the sinews and the flesh came up upon them, and the skin covered them above: but there was no breath in them" (Ezek. 37:7–8). The body is reassembled, but it is not alive. Only afterward does God say, "Come from the four winds, O breath, and breathe upon these slain, that they may live" (Ezek. 37:9), and they stand up "an exceeding great army" (Ezek. 37:10). God then explains the vision himself: "Son of man, these bones are the whole house of Israel" (Ezek. 37:11), and "I shall place you in your own land" (Ezek. 37:14).

This is where Israel stands today. The bones have come together. The nation has been regathered into its land. But there is still no breath in them. As a nation they are not yet regenerated by the Spirit of God. That second stage is still future. This is the difference we have seen throughout the book: national restoration is one thing, and spiritual rebirth is another. God has promised both.

Christians saw this long before 1948. In 1864, when there was no Jewish state and the idea seemed impossible, Charles Spurgeon, a Calvinist, preached on this chapter and said, "The meaning of our text as opened up by the context is most evidently, if words mean anything, first, that there shall be a political restoration of the Jews to their own land and to their own nationality."[4] He took the words to mean what they said, and history proved him right.

Other Promises

The prophets say the same thing in one place after another. "Behold, the days come, saith the LORD, that I will raise unto David a righteous Branch, and a King shall reign and prosper,

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[4]Charles H. Spurgeon, "The Restoration and Conversion of the Jews," sermon preached at the Metropolitan Tabernacle, Newington, June 16, 1864, in *Spurgeon's Sermons*, vol. 10 (1864) (Grand Rapids, MI: Christian Classics Ethereal Library), https://ccel.org/ccel/spurgeon/sermons10.

and shall execute judgment and justice in the earth. In his days Judah shall be saved, and Israel shall dwell safely" (Jer. 23:5–6). God does not speak only of Israel here. He names Judah, one particular tribe. There is a specificity to these promises that cannot be spiritualized away.

Again:

Jeremiah 32:37–38, 40

"Behold, I will gather them out of all countries, whither I have driven them in mine anger, and in my fury, and in great wrath; and I will bring them again unto this place, and I will cause them to dwell safely: And they shall be my people, and I will be their God… And I will make an everlasting covenant with them, that I will not turn away from them, to do them good; but I will put my fear in their hearts, that they shall not depart from me."

How long does an everlasting covenant last? If we cannot believe God when he says everlasting to Israel, we have no business quoting John 3:16.

Hosea records Israel's future repentance: "Come, and let us return unto the LORD: for he hath torn, and he will heal us; he hath smitten, and he will bind us up. After two days will he revive us: in the third day he will raise us up, and we shall live in his sight" (Hos. 6:1–2). Many have noticed that "one day is with the Lord as a thousand years" (2 Pet. 3:8) and have wondered whether Hosea's two days point to the long age of Israel's scattering. We do not set dates, and no one knows the day or the hour. But the promise is clear: God will revive Israel, and they will live in his sight.

They Shall Look upon Me

The prophet Zechariah shows us the moment when the breath comes into the bones. In the day when all nations gather against Jerusalem, God says, "And I will pour upon the house of David, and upon the inhabitants of Jerusalem, the spirit of grace and of supplications: and they shall look upon me whom they have

pierced, and they shall mourn for him, as one mourneth for his only son" (Zech. 12:10). The one speaking is the LORD, and he says they pierced him. Israel will recognize the Messiah they rejected. "In that day there shall be a fountain opened to the house of David and to the inhabitants of Jerusalem for sin and for uncleanness" (Zech. 13:1). And then, "his feet shall stand in that day upon the mount of Olives, which is before Jerusalem on the east" (Zech. 14:4), the very mountain from which he ascended (Acts 1:11–12).

The Lord Jesus himself pointed to this day. After pronouncing judgment on Jerusalem's leaders, he said, "For I say unto you, Ye shall not see me henceforth, till ye shall say, Blessed is he that cometh in the name of the Lord" (Matt. 23:39). The word *till* shows that the rejection was not final. He also said that Jerusalem "shall be trodden down of the Gentiles, until the times of the Gentiles be fulfilled" (Luke 21:24). Again the word *until* sets a limit. There is an end to the times of the Gentiles, and when it comes, Jerusalem's story is not over. He promised the twelve apostles that they would "sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel" (Matt. 19:28). You cannot judge tribes that no longer exist.

Paul summed up what that day will mean for the world: "For if the casting away of them be the reconciling of the world, what shall the receiving of them be, but life from the dead?" (Rom. 11:15). Israel's fall brought the gospel to the Gentiles. Israel's restoration will bring something greater still.

Wilt Thou at This Time Restore the Kingdom?

One more passage deserves attention. After the resurrection, the Lord spent forty days "speaking of the things pertaining to the kingdom of God" (Acts 1:3). At the end of those forty days, the disciples asked him, "Lord, wilt thou at this time restore again the kingdom to Israel?" (Acts 1:6). If the church had replaced Israel, this was the moment to say so. After forty days of teaching about the kingdom, the Lord would certainly have corrected them if their question rested on a false premise.

Instead he said, "It is not for you to know the times or the seasons, which the Father hath put in his own power" (Acts 1:7). He did not deny that the kingdom would be restored to Israel. He told them the timing was in the Father's hands.

The angel had told Mary the same thing before Jesus was born: "the Lord God shall give unto him the throne of his father David: And he shall reign over the house of Jacob for ever; and of his kingdom there shall be no end" (Luke 1:32–33). That is the theme of the whole Bible, the King and his kingdom. The throne of David is a real throne, the house of Jacob is a real people, and the Lord Jesus will reign over them.

THE SCATTERING AND THE RETURN FORETOLD

The prophecies concerning Israel do not stop at the promise of a future restoration. They also describe, in advance and in considerable detail, the dispersion that would come first. When the historical record is placed beside these prophecies, it confirms that Scripture meant what it said about Israel's scattering. That is strong reason to believe it means what it says about Israel's return.

The Scattering Foretold

Moses warned the nation before it entered the land that persistent disobedience would bring exile: "And the LORD shall scatter thee among all people, from the one end of the earth even unto the other" (Deut. 28:64). He added that among the nations Israel would "find no ease, neither shall the sole of thy foot have rest" (Deut. 28:65). Leviticus is equally specific: "And I will scatter you among the heathen, and will draw out a sword after you: and your land shall be desolate, and your cities waste" (Lev. 26:33). Both the scattering of the people and the desolation of the land were foretold.

The Lord Jesus narrowed the prophecy to a particular generation and a particular city. Weeping over Jerusalem, he said that its enemies would "lay thee even with the ground, and thy children within thee; and they shall not leave in thee one stone upon another; because thou knewest not the time of thy visitation" (Luke 19:44). In the Olivet Discourse he added, "And they shall fall by the edge of the sword, and shall be led away captive into all nations: and Jerusalem shall be trodden down of the Gentiles, until the times of the Gentiles be fulfilled" (Luke 21:24).

The Scattering Fulfilled

Less than forty years later these words were fulfilled. The Jewish historian Josephus, who was present with the Roman army during the siege of Jerusalem in A.D. 70, recorded the scale of the catastrophe: "Now the number of those that were carried

captive during this whole war was collected to be ninety-seven thousand; as was the number of those that perished during the whole siege eleven hundred thousand."[5] The Lord had said that they would "fall by the edge of the sword" and be "led away captive." Josephus records both.

A second revolt, under Simon bar Kokhba in A.D. 132–135, completed the desolation. The Roman historian Cassius Dio reports that the emperor Hadrian rebuilt Jerusalem as a pagan city, "naming it Aelia Capitolina, and on the site of the temple of the god he raised a new temple to Jupiter."[6] When the war ended, Dio writes, "five hundred and eighty thousand men were slain in the various raids and battles," and "nearly the whole of Judaea was made desolate."[7] Jerusalem was now literally "trodden down of the Gentiles," and the land lay desolate, exactly as Moses and the Lord Jesus had said.

For the next eighteen centuries the Jewish people lived as the Scriptures had described: scattered "from the one end of the earth even unto the other," frequently without rest, and often without safety. The first half of the prophecy was fulfilled literally and completely.

The Return Foretold

The same prophets who foretold the scattering foretold the return. Isaiah spoke of a second regathering, distinct from the return from Babylon: "And it shall come to pass in that day, that the Lord shall set his hand again the second time to recover the

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[5]Flavius Josephus, *The Wars of the Jews* 6.9.3, trans. William Whiston, Project Gutenberg, https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/2850. Ancient casualty figures are often debated by historians, but the scale of the destruction is not in doubt.

[6]Cassius Dio, *Roman History* 69.12.1, trans. Earnest Cary, Loeb Classical Library (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1925), https://penelope.uchicago.edu/Thayer/E/Roman/Texts/Cassius_Dio/69*.html.

[7]Cassius Dio, *Roman History* 69.14.1–2.

remnant of his people… and shall assemble the outcasts of Israel, and gather together the dispersed of Judah from the four corners of the earth" (Isa. 11:11–12). The return from Babylon came from one empire in the east. This regathering would come "from the four corners of the earth."

Jeremiah went further and said that the final regathering would eclipse even the exodus from Egypt:

Jeremiah 16:14–15

"Therefore, behold, the days come, saith the LORD, that it shall no more be said, The LORD liveth, that brought up the children of Israel out of the land of Egypt; But, The LORD liveth, that brought up the children of Israel from the land of the north, and from all the lands whither he had driven them: and I will bring them again into their land that I gave unto their fathers."

Ezekiel even addressed the land itself, promising that its long desolation would end as the people returned: "But ye, O mountains of Israel, ye shall shoot forth your branches, and yield your fruit to my people of Israel; for they are at hand to come" (Ezek. 36:8). The land that had lain waste would become fruitful again, and its revival would signal that the people were near.

The Return Documented

In the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, after nearly two millennia of dispersion, the return began. On November 2, 1917, the British government issued the Balfour Declaration, stating that "His Majesty's Government view with favour the establishment in Palestine of a national home for the Jewish people."[8] Thirty years later, on May 14, 1948, the Jewish leadership in the land declared "the establishment of a Jewish State in Eretz-Israel, to be known as the State of Israel." The

[8]Arthur James Balfour to Lord Rothschild, November 2, 1917, The Avalon Project, Yale Law School, https://avalon.law.yale.edu/20th_century/balfour.asp.

declaration itself described the long history the prophets had foretold: "After being forcibly exiled from their land, the people remained faithful to it throughout their Dispersion and never ceased to pray and hope for their return to it." It also declared that the new state "will be open for Jewish immigration and for the Ingathering of the Exiles."[9]

The phrase "Ingathering of the Exiles" is the language of the prophets. Those who wrote it did not, for the most part, believe that Jesus is the Messiah, and many were not religious at all. That is precisely what Ezekiel foresaw: a people gathered into their own land first, and cleansed and given a new heart afterward (Ezek. 36:24–26). God is using the decisions of statesmen, as he used the decree of Cyrus, to accomplish what he promised.

Why This Matters for Interpretation

The replacement view teaches that the prophecies of Israel's return were fulfilled spiritually in the church. But the prophecies of Israel's scattering were not fulfilled spiritually. They were fulfilled in history, with swords, captives, a ruined temple, and a desolate land, all of it recorded by Jewish and Roman historians who had no interest in confirming the Bible. It would be strange to insist that the curses of Deuteronomy 28 and Luke 21 were literal while the promises attached to them are only figures of speech. The same God who kept his word in judgment is keeping it in restoration. "Surely as I have thought, so shall it come to pass; and as I have purposed, so shall it stand" (Isa. 14:24).

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[9]Declaration of the Establishment of the State of Israel, May 14, 1948, The Avalon Project, Yale Law School, https://avalon.law.yale.edu/20th_century/israel.asp.

A PEOPLE PRESERVED

Observers of history have long noted the remarkable survival of the Jewish people. They have been hated and persecuted in nearly every age, yet they remain. Empires that tried to destroy them are gone, and the Jewish people remain. For those who read the Bible, this is one of the greatest physical evidences that God is real and that his word is true. God said he would preserve them, and he has.

Picture After Picture

The history of Israel is a series of near destructions and revivals. They went into captivity in Babylon and were nearly swallowed up, and God brought a remnant back. Rome destroyed Jerusalem and scattered them across the earth, and they survived. During the centuries when the Roman church dominated Europe, Jews were expelled, forcibly converted, and killed, and still they survived. In the twentieth century Hitler set out to exterminate them, and some six million were murdered. Within a few years of that horror, the nation of Israel was declared in 1948.

Each of those episodes is a smaller picture of what is coming. The tribulation will be worse than all of them combined. Satan knows that if he could destroy Israel he could make God a liar, and that is why the dragon of Revelation 12 is so fixed on the woman. But God has promised that the nation will not cease from before him as long as the sun and moon endure (Jer. 31:35–36).

Few peoples in history have been scattered so far for so long and then regathered as a nation in their ancient land, with their ancient language revived as a living tongue. That is what has happened to Israel. Ezekiel's bones came together in our lifetime.

The scattering and the regathering were both foretold before Israel ever entered the land. Moses warned, "And the LORD

shall scatter thee among all people, from the one end of the earth even unto the other" (Deut. 28:64). Then he promised:

Deuteronomy 30:3–4

"That then the LORD thy God will turn thy captivity, and have compassion upon thee, and will return and gather thee from all the nations, whither the LORD thy God hath scattered thee. If any of thine be driven out unto the outmost parts of heaven, from thence will the LORD thy God gather thee, and from thence will he fetch thee."

The return from Babylon was a regathering from one nation. Moses spoke of a gathering from all nations, from the ends of heaven.

Isaiah made the distinction explicit:

Isaiah 11:11–12

"And it shall come to pass in that day, that the Lord shall set his hand again the second time to recover the remnant of his people… And he shall set up an ensign for the nations, and shall assemble the outcasts of Israel, and gather together the dispersed of Judah from the four corners of the earth."

The first time God recovered his people, he brought them back from Babylon. The second time, he gathers them from the four corners of the earth. We have lived to see Jews return from Russia and Ethiopia, from Yemen and Argentina, from every corner of the globe.

Even the prophet Balaam, hired to curse Israel, had to say, "lo, the people shall dwell alone, and shall not be reckoned among the nations" (Num. 23:9). Israel has never been one nation among the rest. And Isaiah asked a question that many have connected with the day in May 1948 when Israel's independence was declared: "Who hath heard such a thing? who hath seen such things? Shall the earth be made to bring forth in one day? or shall a nation be born at once? for as soon as Zion travailed, she brought forth her children" (Isa. 66:8). Whether or not that verse was aimed at that very day, the principle stands: God can

bring forth a nation in a day, and he has promised to do it for Israel.

1948 and the Literal Reading of Scripture

It is understandable that some Christians in earlier centuries began to reinterpret the promises to Israel. Israel had been gone as a nation for most of two thousand years. Looking around, many concluded that the prophecies of restoration must have been meant spiritually. Then 1948 happened, and the literal reading was vindicated in front of the whole world.

It is easy to say that we only see these things now because they have already happened. But Bible believers expected the restoration before it came. Spurgeon preached it in 1864. Clarence Larkin, whose famous charts were published in the early twentieth century, taught from the prophets that Israel would be restored as a nation before the end. His chart of "The Mountain Peaks of Prophecy" illustrates why the Old Testament prophets saw Israel's promises running straight from the sufferings of Christ to his glory, without seeing the valley of the church age in between.[10] The prophets saw the peaks. They did not see the valley in which we now live. That valley does not cancel the peak on the other side of it.

Larkin also taught the order of events that Ezekiel describes. Israel, he wrote, "is to be gathered back to their own land, where they are to be first judged, (Ez. 20:34–38; 22:19–22), and then converted. Ez. 36:24–27."[11] First the regathering, then the fire of judgment, then the new heart. He wrote that when there was no

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[10]Clarence Larkin, *Dispensational Truth, or God's Plan and Purpose in the Ages* rev. and enl. ed. (Philadelphia: Clarence Larkin, 1920), chap. 3, "Mountain Peaks of Prophecy." Larkin wrote that the prophet "did not see that these peaks assembled themselves in groups, with a valley, the 'VALLEY OF THE CHURCH,' between."

[11]Larkin, *Dispensational Truth*, chap. 9, "The Jews." Larkin placed the full regathering after the rapture of the church; his point was the order of events, not a date.

Jewish state, and the years since have followed the pattern he found in the prophets: the bones have come together, the nation has passed through fire, and the breath is still to come.

Are Modern Jews Really Israel?

Some try to escape all this by denying that the people living in Israel today are Israelites at all. One popular theory says that most modern Jews descend from the Khazars, a Turkic people in the region of the Caucasus whose rulers, according to some sources, converted to Judaism between the eighth and tenth centuries. On this view the Jews of today are not descended from Jacob but from converted Turks.[12]

The Bible does not address the Khazars by name, but it does tell us that God will seal twelve thousand from each tribe of Israel in the tribulation (Rev. 7:4–8), so the tribes must still exist and God knows exactly where they are. Beyond that, genetic research has not supported the Khazar theory. A major genome-wide study concluded that there was no evidence of a Khazar origin for Ashkenazi Jews and found that Jewish populations cluster with other Middle Eastern peoples.[13] Some admixture with surrounding peoples over two thousand years of exile is to be expected, and the Bible itself records Gentiles joining Israel. But the claim that the Jews are not really Jews does not stand up.

Other genome-wide research points the same way. A 2010 study of seven Jewish communities, from Iran and Iraq to Italy, Greece, and eastern Europe, found distinct Jewish population clusters, "each with shared Middle Eastern ancestry," and concluded that

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[12]The theory was popularized by Arthur Koestler, *The Thirteenth Tribe: The Khazar Empire and Its Heritage* (New York: Random House, 1976).

[13]Doron M. Behar et al., "No Evidence from Genome-Wide Data of a Khazar Origin for the Ashkenazi Jews," *Human Biology* 85, no. 6 (2013): 859–900. For the most prominent dissenting argument, see Eran Elhaik, "The Missing Link of Jewish European Ancestry: Contrasting the Rhineland and the Khazarian Hypotheses," *Genome Biology and Evolution* 5, no. 1 (2013): 61–74.

the evidence "refuted large-scale genetic contributions of Central and Eastern European and Slavic populations to the formation of Ashkenazi Jewry."[14] After two thousand years of scattering among the nations, the Jewish people still carry the marks of where they came from. The scientists did not set out to confirm the Bible, but they have confirmed what it says: the people God scattered are the people he is gathering.

It also helps to remember what happened in 1948 and after. Before the modern state was declared, the land was home to many peoples. Since then, Jewish immigrants have poured in from Russia, Poland, North Africa, America, and all over the world, many of them survivors and refugees. The nation that exists today was built largely from the scattered descendants of the people the prophets said would be gathered.

The numbers themselves are remarkable. When the state was declared in 1948, Israel had about 806,000 residents. In April 2026 its Central Bureau of Statistics reported a population of more than ten million, and it recorded more than three and a half million immigrants who had arrived since 1948. About 45 percent of all the Jews in the world now live in the land.[15] Nothing like this has happened to any other ancient people. "Behold, I will gather them out of all countries" (Jer. 32:37). This promise is being fulfilled in our own generation.

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[14]Gil Atzmon et al., "Abraham's Children in the Genome Era: Major Jewish Diaspora Populations Comprise Distinct Genetic Clusters with Shared Middle Eastern Ancestry," *American Journal of Human Genetics* 86, no. 6 (2010): 850–59. See also Doron M. Behar et al., "The Genome-Wide Structure of the Jewish People," *Nature* 466 (2010): 238–42.

[15]Central Bureau of Statistics figures reported in "Israel's Population Grew 1.4% over Past Year," *Globes*, April 22, 2026, https://en.globes.co.il/en/article-1001540684; and "As Israel Approaches 78th Independence Day, Its Population Stands at 10.244 Million," *Times of Israel*, April 2026, https://www.timesofisrael.com/as-israel-approaches-78th-independence-day-its-population-stands-at-10-244-million/.

A related error is taught by various groups known as Black Hebrew Israelites, who claim that the true Israelites are black people, often African Americans, and that today's Jews are impostors. They tend to build this on one or two passages, especially Deuteronomy 28:68, while ignoring the rest of the Bible. Some teach that salvation belongs only to those of the twelve tribes, which contradicts the whole gospel. Like the Khazar theory, it is one more way of saying, "They are not the real Israel. We are."

Islam and the Children of Abraham

Islam is also, in its own way, a form of replacement theology. It claims Abraham as its father, but through Ishmael rather than Isaac, and the Qur'an says, "Abraham was neither a Jew nor a Christian, but he was one inclining toward truth, a Muslim."[16] In this view the promises passed away from Israel and now belong to Islam. It is no accident that the religion that claims Israel's inheritance is also the one most openly devoted to Israel's destruction.

People who have lived and worked among Arabs and Jews in the Middle East often say the same thing: each side refers to the other as cousins. This is what Genesis records. Isaac and Ishmael were brothers, and the conflict between their descendants is an ancient family quarrel. The Bible explains the headlines better than any newspaper can.

Bad Doctrine, Bad Fruit

Hatred of the Jewish people has never gone away, and in our own day attacks on Jewish gatherings in various parts of the world remind us how deep it runs. Doctrine affects life. Paul told Titus that believers should "adorn the doctrine of God our Saviour in all things" (Titus 2:10). True doctrine produces a certain kind of life, and false doctrine does the same. It is no

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[16]Qur'an 3:67, Saheeh International translation, https://quran.com/3/67.

coincidence that those who teach that God has cast away Israel so often speak of the Jewish people with contempt. If you believe God is finished with them, it is a short step to treating them as though they were cursed.

The warning of Romans 11 applies: "Boast not against the branches." And the promise of Genesis 12 has never been repealed: "I will bless them that bless thee, and curse him that curseth thee" (Gen. 12:3). The nations that have tried to destroy the Jews have not fared well. Christians have no business joining them.

HOW THE IDEA ENTERED THE CHURCH

If the Bible is this clear, how did so many Christians come to believe that the church replaced Israel? The answer lies in church history, and God himself gave us a remarkable window into it.

The Synagogue of Satan

In the letters to the seven churches, the Lord Jesus twice speaks of people who claim to be Jews and are not. To Smyrna he said, "I know the blasphemy of them which say they are Jews, and are not, but are the synagogue of Satan" (Rev. 2:9). To Philadelphia he said, "Behold, I will make them of the synagogue of Satan, which say they are Jews, and are not, but do lie; behold, I will make them to come and worship before thy feet, and to know that I have loved thee" (Rev. 3:9).

Many Bible teachers believe that the seven churches of Revelation 2 and 3, besides being real churches in John's day, also picture the course of church history from the apostles to the end of the age. God did not take two chapters out of the revelation of his Son merely to write to seven random congregations. Teachers who hold this view do not all draw the dates in exactly the same place. In the outline we follow, Smyrna pictures roughly the second through early fourth centuries, the age of the great persecutions, and Philadelphia pictures the era from about the Reformation to around 1900. With that outline in mind, look at what history records.

Smyrna: The Idea Appears

It was in the Smyrna period that Christians first began to claim openly that they were the true Israel. Around A.D. 160, Justin Martyr wrote in his *Dialogue with Trypho*, a debate with a Jewish man, "For the true spiritual Israel, and descendants of Judah, Jacob, Isaac, and Abraham… are we who have been led to God

through this crucified Christ."[17] Writers such as Irenaeus of Lyons followed in the same general direction. Here were Christians saying they were Jews, the descendants of Judah and Jacob, and they were not. The very claim the Lord condemned in the letter to Smyrna surfaced in the period Smyrna represents.

The claim was already being made even before Justin. The so-called *Epistle of Barnabas*, written in the early second century, warned its readers "not to be like some, adding largely to your sins, and saying, 'The covenant is both theirs and ours.'" The writer insisted that the Jews "thus finally lost it" when Israel made the golden calf.[18] In other words, it was already considered a sin to say that God's covenant still belonged to Israel. That is replacement theology in its earliest recorded form, and it appeared in exactly the period the letter to Smyrna pictures.

Augustine: The Idea Becomes Mainstream

The idea became mainstream through Augustine, bishop of Hippo, who wrote *The City of God* in the early fifth century (A.D. 413–426). Augustine taught that the thousand years of Revelation 20 were not a future kingdom but the present age of the church. "Therefore the Church even now is the kingdom of Christ, and the kingdom of heaven," he wrote.[19] If the church is already the kingdom, the promises of an earthly kingdom to Israel have nowhere to go but into the church.

Augustine also taught that the Jews had been "utterly rooted out from their kingdom" and "dispersed through the lands," and

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[17]Justin Martyr, *Dialogue with Trypho* 11, in *The Ante-Nicene Fathers*, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson, vol. 1 (Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1885).

[18]*The Epistle of Barnabas* 4, in *The Ante-Nicene Fathers*, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson, vol. 1 (Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1885). The translators note that the Greek text reads simply "the covenant is ours."

[19]Augustine, *The City of God* 20.9, trans. Marcus Dods, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 1st ser., vol. 2, ed. Philip Schaff (New York: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1890).

that they survived as a testimony to Christians that the prophecies about Christ had not been forged.[20] On this view Israel had no future of its own. Its purpose was to be scattered as a witness. That thinking shaped the Roman church for the next thousand years. The medieval church viewed itself as the new Israel, Rome as the center of God's kingdom, and the Jews as a cursed people. The Crusades sought to win the holy city for Christendom, and Jews across Europe suffered expulsions, forced baptisms, and massacres.

It is worth comparing the name of Augustine's great book with what the Lord promised the overcomers at Philadelphia: "I will write upon him the name of my God, and the name of the city of my God, which is new Jerusalem, which cometh down out of heaven from my God" (Rev. 3:12). The city of God is not Rome, and it is not the church on earth. It is new Jerusalem.

The Fruit in Church History

Once the church regarded itself as the new Israel and the Jews as a people cast off by God, the consequences followed quickly. In A.D. 386–387, John Chrysostom, the most celebrated preacher of the Greek church, delivered a series of sermons at Antioch against Christians who were attending synagogue festivals. In the first of them he declared, "the synagogue is not only a brothel and a theater; it also is a den of robbers and a lodging for wild beasts."[21] These were not the words of an obscure figure. Chrysostom was honored as a saint and a doctor of the church, and his sermons were read for centuries.

The medieval church turned such attitudes into law. The Fourth Lateran Council of 1215, the most important council of the Middle Ages, decreed in its sixty-eighth canon that Jews and

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[20]Augustine, *The City of God* 18.46.

[21]John Chrysostom, *Against the Jews*, homily 1.3.1, English translation as posted in *Early Church Fathers: Additional Texts*, ed. Roger Pearse, https://www.tertullian.org/fathers/chrysostom_adversus_judaeos_01_homily1.htm.

Muslims "in every Christian province and at all times shall be marked off in the eyes of the public from other peoples through the character of their dress."[22] Distinctive badges and dress marked Jewish communities across Europe for centuries afterward, and expulsions and massacres followed in many lands. The theology that said God had finished with Israel produced a church that treated Israel as an enemy. The Reformation did not break this pattern at first, as the case of Luther shows.

Philadelphia: The Idea Revived

After Augustine the idea lived on mainly within the Roman church. Then it was revived by the leading figures of the Reformation, which in our outline falls in the time of Philadelphia, the very letter where the Lord again mentions those "which say they are Jews, and are not, but do lie."

Martin Luther at first spoke sympathetically of the Jews, hoping they would be converted. When they were not, he wrote *On the Jews and Their Lies* (1543), one of the most bitter treatises ever written against the Jewish people. John Calvin, trained in the Roman church and deeply devoted to Augustine, whose works he referred to more than four thousand times,[23] taught that God's covenant with Israel and his covenant with the church were in substance one covenant. "The covenant made with all the fathers is so far from differing from ours in reality and substance, that it is altogether one and the same: still the

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[22]Fourth Lateran Council (1215), canon 68, in H. J. Schroeder, *Disciplinary Decrees of the General Councils: Text, Translation and Commentary* (St. Louis: B. Herder, 1937), as reproduced in the Internet Medieval Sourcebook, Fordham University, https://sourcebooks.fordham.edu/basis/lateran4.asp.

[23]Luchesius Smits counted 4,119 references to Augustine in Calvin's writings, 1,175 of them in the *Institutes*. Luchesius Smits, *Saint Augustin dans l'oeuvre de Jean Calvin*, vol. 1 (Assen: Van Gorcum, 1957), 271ff., as tabulated in Graham Joseph Hill, "Augustine's Influence on Calvin, Luther, and Zwingli," https://grahamjosephhill.com/augustines-influence-calvin-luther-zwingli/.

administration differs," he wrote.[24] We have already seen how he extended "all Israel" in Romans 11:26 to mean all the people of God. The covenant theology that grew out of the Reformed tradition carried this approach forward, and many of today's most popular teachers stand in that line.

The contrast between the two Luthers is stark. In 1523 he had complained that Christians treated the Jews "as if they were dogs."[25] Twenty years later, having decided that God had rejected them, he gave the princes this counsel: "First, to set fire to their synagogues or schools and to bury and cover with dirt whatever will not burn, so that no man will ever again see a stone or cinder of them." He went on to advise that their houses be razed, their prayer books taken, and their rabbis forbidden to teach on pain of death.[26] Four centuries later, Nazi propagandists reprinted Luther's words. That is where the idea that God has finished with the Jews can lead.

Rome Changes Its Tone

Something else is worth noticing. Within two decades of Israel's rebirth, Rome itself changed its public posture toward the Jews. At the Second Vatican Council, the declaration *Nostra Aetate* (1965) stated that "the Jews should not be presented as rejected or accursed by God, as if this followed from the Holy Scriptures."[27] That is a remarkable change from the attitude of

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[24]John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion* 2.10.2, trans. Henry Beveridge (Edinburgh: Calvin Translation Society, 1845).

[25]Quoted in "Jews, Lies, and Nazis," *Christian History*, Christian History Institute, https://christianhistoryinstitute.org/magazine/article/jews-lies-and-nazis.

[26]Martin Luther, *On the Jews and Their Lies*, trans. Martin H. Bertram, in *Luther's Works*, vol. 47 (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1971). The full passage is reproduced by the Council of Centers on Jewish-Christian Relations at https://www.ccjr.us/dialogika-resources/primary-texts/luther-1543.

[27]Second Vatican Council, *Nostra Aetate* (Declaration on the Relation of the Church to Non-Christian Religions), October 28, 1965, sec. 4,

the Dark Ages and the Crusades. It did not mean Rome abandoned its claim to be the one true church. It is one more sign that 1948 changed the conversation, and that events are moving in the direction the prophets foretold.

The pattern is striking. The Lord condemned those who say they are Jews and are not in two letters. The claim appeared in the early church in the period Smyrna represents, and it was revived with force by the great names of the Reformation. However one dates the church ages, the words of the Lord stand: saying you are a Jew when you are not is not a small theological preference. He calls it the synagogue of Satan.

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https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist_councils/ii_vatican_council/documents/vat-ii_decl_19651028_nostra-aetate_en.html.

A HOPE THE CHURCH NEVER LOST

Advocates of replacement theology often claim that belief in a future for national Israel is a recent invention, usually traced to the dispensational teachers of the nineteenth century. The historical record does not support that claim. Although the view that the church had replaced Israel became dominant after Augustine, the expectation of a literal kingdom centered in Jerusalem, and later the expectation of Israel's national restoration and conversion, was held by Christians in nearly every period of church history.

The Earliest Expectation

The same Justin Martyr who first called the church "the true spiritual Israel" also expected a literal kingdom in a rebuilt Jerusalem. In the same *Dialogue with Trypho* he wrote, "But I and others, who are right-minded Christians on all points, are assured that there will be a resurrection of the dead, and a thousand years in Jerusalem, which will then be built, adorned, and enlarged, [as] the prophets Ezekiel and Isaiah and others declare."[28] Justin was candid that not all Christians agreed; he acknowledged that "many who belong to the pure and pious faith, and are true Christians, think otherwise."[29] But he took the prophecies of Ezekiel and Isaiah about a restored Jerusalem at face value.

Irenaeus of Lyons, writing around A.D. 180, reasoned in the same way about the promise of the land. Abraham was promised the land "from the river of Egypt even unto the great river Euphrates," yet he never possessed it during his lifetime. Irenaeus concluded: "If, then, God promised him the inheritance of the land, yet he did not receive it during all the time of his

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[28]Justin Martyr, *Dialogue with Trypho* 80, in *The Ante-Nicene Fathers*, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson, vol. 1 (Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1885).

[29]Justin Martyr, *Dialogue with Trypho* 80.

sojourn there, it must be, that together with his seed… he shall receive it at the resurrection of the just."[30] Irenaeus, like Justin, applied the term "seed" to the church, and on that point we differ from him. But he refused to spiritualize the land. The promise concerned real territory, and it would be fulfilled.

These early writers show that the first Christians who began to call themselves Israel had not yet abandoned the literal meaning of the prophets. The complete spiritualizing of the promises came later, through the allegorical method associated with Origen of Alexandria and, above all, through Augustine.

Augustine's Own Admission

Augustine himself had once shared the older hope. In *The City of God*, where he set out the view that the thousand years of Revelation 20 are the present church age, he admitted that the expectation of a future Sabbath-age of a thousand years "would not be objectionable, if it were believed that the joys of the saints in that Sabbath shall be spiritual," and added, "for I myself, too, once held this opinion."[31] Augustine's objection was largely to the crude descriptions of feasting that some attached to the millennium. Yet in rejecting those excesses, he rejected the future earthly kingdom altogether, and his authority carried the Western church with him for a thousand years.

The Hope Recovered After the Reformation

After the Reformation, as Christians returned to the careful study of the prophets, the expectation of a future for Israel reappeared, even among those who held Reformed theology in other respects. The Savoy Declaration of 1658, the confession of the English Congregationalists, modified the Westminster Confession at this very point. It stated, "we expect that in the

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[30]Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 5.32.2, in *The Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 1.

[31]Augustine, *The City of God* 20.7, trans. Marcus Dods, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 1st ser., vol. 2, ed. Philip Schaff (New York: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1890).

latter days, Antichrist being destroyed, the Jews called, and the adversaries of the kingdom of his dear Son broken, the churches of Christ being enlarged and edified… shall enjoy in this world a more quiet, peaceable, and glorious condition than they have enjoyed."[32] A confession written nearly two centuries before modern dispensationalism expected "the Jews called" in the latter days.

In the nineteenth century, the evangelical Anglican bishop J. C. Ryle, whose views of salvation were decidedly Reformed, set out his "prophetical creed" in a series of propositions. The seventh reads: "I believe that the Jews shall ultimately be gathered again as a separate nation, restored to their own land, and converted to the faith of Christ, after going through great tribulation." He supported it with Jeremiah 30 and 31, Romans 11, Daniel 12, and Zechariah 13.[33] Charles Spurgeon, as we have seen, preached the same expectation from Ezekiel 37 in 1864.

What the Record Shows

The record, then, is not that belief in Israel's future is a modern novelty. The earliest Christians expected a literal restoration of Jerusalem. The spiritualizing view became dominant only when Augustine, who had once held the older view himself, gave it his authority. And when believers after the Reformation returned to the text of the prophets, many of them, including men who were Reformed in their view of salvation, recovered the expectation that "all Israel shall be saved" (Rom. 11:26) as a nation in the last

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[32]Savoy Declaration (1658), chap. 26, sec. 5, in Philip Schaff, ed., *The Creeds of Christendom*, vol. 3, *The Evangelical Protestant Creeds*, 4th ed., rev. and enl. (1877; repr., Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House), Christian Classics Ethereal Library, https://ccel.org/ccel/schaff/creeds3.

[33]J. C. Ryle, preface to *Coming Events and Present Duties: Sermons on Prophetical Subjects*, 2nd ed. (London: William Hunt, 1879), proposition 7.

days. The consistent factor is not a particular school of theology. It is the willingness to read the prophets as they were written.

CONCLUSION: ISRAEL MEANS ISRAEL

We have walked through the passages that are used to teach that the church has replaced Israel, and we have found that none of them says so when read in context. Romans 2 is about individual justification, and the next verses affirm the Jew's advantage. Galatians 3 is about access to Christ, and the chapter before it affirms a ministry to the circumcision. Romans 9 distinguishes a believing remnant within Israel, and its "Jacob have I loved" is about nations. Romans 11 says God has not cast away his people, that the Gentiles are grafted into Israel's own tree, and that all Israel shall be saved.

If You Spiritualize Israel, Be Careful

There is a danger in spiritualizing the promises to Israel that many do not consider. If the land, the throne, the tribes, and the everlasting covenant made to Israel do not mean what they say, then by the same method the promises made to us need not mean what they say either. The resurrection of the body, the catching away of the church, a real heaven, and a glorified body are all promises as literal as anything God said to Abraham. We cannot take our promises literally and make theirs figures of speech. "God is not a man, that he should lie; neither the son of man, that he should repent: hath he said, and shall he not do it? or hath he spoken, and shall he not make it good?" (Num. 23:19). "For the gifts and calling of God are without repentance" (Rom. 11:29).

The Heart Behind It

There is also a spirit behind replacement theology that deserves to be named. Satan's quarrel with God has always been that God got it wrong. He wanted to be "like the most High" (Isa. 14:14), and he has spent all of history trying to prove that God's choices were mistakes. Judas walked with Christ and seems to have decided that the Lord was going about the kingdom the wrong way. The same attitude can creep into our theology. It amounts to saying that God chose the wrong people and that those who

rejected his Son can no longer be his. That attitude is the boasting against the branches that Paul forbids. It is the opposite of the humility that should mark a Gentile who has been grafted into a tree that was never his by nature.

What Should We Do?

First, we should read our Bibles and believe what they say. When God says Israel, he means Israel. When he says everlasting, he means everlasting. Take the Bible for what it says and let it define its own terms, and most of this confusion will disappear.

Second, we should give the gospel to the Jewish people. God's national plan does not save any individual apart from Christ. The gospel is still "the power of God unto salvation to every one that believeth; to the Jew first, and also to the Greek" (Rom. 1:16). Our love for Israel should look like Paul's: heaviness of heart and prayer to God that they might be saved.

Third, we should refuse to boast against the branches. We can disagree with the policies of a modern government and still recognize that God has not finished with the nation. We are commanded, "Pray for the peace of Jerusalem: they shall prosper that love thee" (Ps. 122:6).

Finally, we should take comfort. The God who kept his word to Abraham through four thousand years of Israel's unfaithfulness will keep his word to us. The same faithfulness that preserves Israel preserves every believer. The inclusion of the church does not cancel Israel's promises, and it does not need to. God has room in his plan for both, and his promises to both will stand.

APPENDIX: PROMISES OF ISRAEL'S FUTURE

Throughout this book we have said that the promises of Israel's restoration are "all over the Bible." This appendix gathers the main passages in one place so that readers can study them for themselves. The summaries are ours; read each passage in its setting and let it speak.

The Covenants

Genesis 12:1–3, 7 — God promises to make of Abram a great nation and gives the land to his seed.

Genesis 13:14–15 — All the land Abram can see is given to him and to his seed for ever.

Genesis 15:7–21 — God alone passes between the pieces, binding himself to give the land from the river of Egypt to the Euphrates.

Genesis 17:7–8 — An everlasting covenant with Abraham's seed and the land as an everlasting possession.

Genesis 26:3–4 — The oath to Abraham confirmed to Isaac.

Genesis 28:13–15 — The land promise confirmed to Jacob, with the promise that God will not leave him.

Leviticus 26:40–45 — Even in the land of their enemies God will not cast Israel away or break his covenant.

Deuteronomy 4:29–31 — In the latter days Israel will return to the Lord, who will not forget the covenant of their fathers.

Deuteronomy 30:1–6 — Regathering from all nations, return to the land, and circumcision of the heart.

2 Samuel 7:12–16 — David's house, kingdom, and throne established for ever.

Psalm 89:28–37 — David's children's sin will be chastened, but the covenant will not be broken.

Psalm 105:8–11 — The covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob is an everlasting covenant concerning the land of Canaan.

The Prophets

Isaiah 11:11–12 — The Lord will recover his people a second time, from the four corners of the earth.

Isaiah 14:1–2 — The Lord will yet choose Israel and set them in their own land.

Isaiah 43:5–7 — God will gather Israel's seed from east, west, north, and south.

Isaiah 49:14–16 — God cannot forget Zion; she is graven on the palms of his hands.

Isaiah 54:7–10 — God's covenant of peace with Israel will not be removed, though the mountains depart.

Isaiah 59:20–21 — The Redeemer comes to Zion, and God's covenant with Jacob's seed stands for ever.

Isaiah 66:7–9 — A nation born at once; Zion brings forth her children.

Jeremiah 16:14–15 — A regathering from the north and all lands that will eclipse the exodus from Egypt.

Jeremiah 23:5–8 — The righteous Branch of David reigns; Judah is saved and Israel dwells safely.

Jeremiah 30:3, 7–11 — Return to the land, the time of Jacob's trouble, and the promise that God will not make a full end of Israel.

Jeremiah 31:31–37 — The new covenant with the house of Israel and the house of Judah, guaranteed by the ordinances of heaven.

Jeremiah 32:37–41 — Gathered from all countries, given one heart, and planted in the land with an everlasting covenant.

Jeremiah 33:14–26 — The Branch of David, and the covenant with Jacob and David as sure as day and night.

Ezekiel 11:17–20 — Gathered from the countries, given the land of Israel, and given a new heart.

Ezekiel 20:33–38 — Brought out from the nations, judged in the wilderness, and brought into the bond of the covenant.

Ezekiel 36:22–28 — Regathered for God's holy name's sake, then cleansed and given a new heart and spirit.

Ezekiel 37:1–14 — The valley of dry bones: the whole house of Israel restored, then given breath.

Ezekiel 37:21–28 — One nation under one king, David, with an everlasting covenant of peace.

Ezekiel 39:25–29 — God will bring again the captivity of Jacob and pour out his spirit on the house of Israel.

Daniel 9:24–27 — Seventy weeks determined upon Daniel's people and his holy city.

Daniel 12:1. A time of trouble such as never was, and Daniel's people delivered.

Hosea 3:4–5 — Many days without a king, afterward Israel returns and seeks David their king in the latter days.

Joel 3:1, 20 — God brings again the captivity of Judah and Jerusalem, and Judah dwells for ever.

Amos 9:11–15 — The tabernacle of David raised up; Israel planted in their land, never again to be pulled up.

Micah 4:6–7 — The Lord gathers the outcast and reigns over them in mount Zion for ever.

Zephaniah 3:14–20 — The King of Israel in the midst of Zion; the scattered gathered and given praise among all people.

Zechariah 8:7–8 — God saves his people from the east and west and brings them to dwell in Jerusalem.

Zechariah 12:10–13:1. Israel looks on him whom they pierced, mourns, and a fountain is opened for sin.

Zechariah 14:4, 9 — The Lord's feet on the mount of Olives, and the Lord king over all the earth.

The New Testament

Matthew 19:28 — The apostles will sit on twelve thrones judging the twelve tribes of Israel.

Matthew 23:39 — Jerusalem will not see Christ again until they say, Blessed is he that cometh.

Luke 1:32–33 — Christ will have the throne of David and reign over the house of Jacob for ever.

Luke 21:24 — Jerusalem trodden down until the times of the Gentiles are fulfilled.

Acts 1:6–7 — The disciples ask about restoring the kingdom to Israel; the Lord speaks only of timing.

Acts 3:19–21 — Heaven receives Christ until the times of restitution spoken by all the prophets.

Acts 15:16–17 — After this God will return and build again the tabernacle of David.

Romans 11:1–2, 11–12 — God has not cast away his people; their stumbling is not a final fall.

Romans 11:25–29 — Blindness in part until the fulness of the Gentiles; all Israel saved; the gifts and calling without repentance.

Revelation 7:4–8 — Twelve thousand sealed from each of the tribes of Israel.

Revelation 12:1–17 — The woman with twelve stars, persecuted by the dragon and preserved in the wilderness.

Revelation 21:12 — The names of the twelve tribes written on the gates of new Jerusalem.

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